YEAR 2 · UNIT 21 · DAYS 753-784

Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians

Galatians, 1-2 Corinthians

The sufficiency of grace. The cross as the center of everything.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me."

GALATIANS 2:20

Psalms 33, 62, 111, 112, and 133 on trust, generosity, and unity.

UNIT 21

In this unit

WEEK 108

753	Galatians 1:1-2:21	*Reading*
754	Romans 8:14-17; Galatians 4:1-7; 1 John 3:1-3	*Doctrine*
755	Galatians 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
756	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 109

757	Galatians 5:1-6:18	*Reading*
758	1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16	*Reading*
759	1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21	*Reading*
760	Psalm 33	*Psalm*
761	Psalm 62	*Psalm*
762	1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40	*Reading*
763	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 110

764	1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33	*Reading*
765	1 Corinthians 11:17-34; Luke 22:14-20; Matthew 26:26-29	*Doctrine*
766	1 Corinthians 11:1-34	*Reading*
767	1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40	*Reading*
768	1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-16	*Doctrine*
769	Psalm 111	*Psalm*
770	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 111

771	Psalm 112	*Psalm*
772	Psalm 133	*Psalm*
773	1 Corinthians 15:1-58	*Reading*
774	1 Corinthians 15:1-28; Matthew 28:1-10	*Doctrine*

775	1 Corinthians 15:35-58; Daniel 12:1-3; John 5:28-29	*Doctrine*
776	1 Corinthians 16:1-24	*Reading*
777	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 112

778	2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18	*Reading*
779	2 Corinthians 5:1-10; Philippians 1:21-24; Luke 23:39-43	*Doctrine*
780	2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21	*Reading*
781	2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15	*Reading*
782	2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14	*Reading*
783	Review and Reflection	*Review*
784	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 753 · WEEK 108

Galatians 1:1-2:21

No other gospel; Paul's apostleship; justification by faith

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 1:1-2:21. This is Paul's most urgent letter. Notice that he skips the usual thanksgiving and goes straight to alarm. Read his defense of the gospel and of his apostleship, and end with 2:15-21, the heart of the matter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Galatians is probably Paul's earliest letter, written around AD 48 to 49 to churches he founded in the region of Galatia (in modern Turkey). After he left, teachers came who insisted that Gentile believers must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses to be truly part of God's people. Paul sees that this is not a minor disagreement but a different gospel. The letter is his passionate defense of salvation by grace through faith in Christ alone. It was Martin Luther's favorite letter, and he called it his "Katie von Bora."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father" (1:4).
2. "I am astonished that you are so quickly deserting him who called you in the grace of Christ and are turning to a different gospel" (1:6).
3. "But even if we or an angel from heaven should preach to you a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you, let him be accursed" (1:8).
4. "For I did not receive it from any man, nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ" (1:12).
5. "I opposed him to his face, because he stood condemned" (2:11).

6. “Yet we know that a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ” (2:16).
7. “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (2:20).
8. “I do not nullify the grace of God, for if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose” (2:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens by stressing that he is an apostle “not from men nor through man, but through Jesus Christ and God the Father, who raised him from the dead.” His authority and message come from Christ. Even his greeting contains the gospel: Christ “gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age.” Then, instead of a thanksgiving, he says, “I am astonished.” The Galatians are deserting the one who called them in grace. There is no other gospel, only some who trouble you and want to distort the gospel of Christ. He pronounces a curse on anyone, even an angel, who preaches a different gospel. This is strong language because the gospel is not negotiable.

He defends his own gospel by telling his story. He once persecuted the church violently and was advancing in Judaism beyond many of his peers. But God, who had set him apart from his mother’s womb, was pleased to reveal his Son to him. He did not consult with flesh and blood, but went to Arabia and returned to Damascus. Three years later he visited Peter in Jerusalem for fifteen days; he met James, the Lord’s brother. The churches of Judea glorified God because of him.

After fourteen years, he went again to Jerusalem with Barnabas and Titus, and laid before the leaders the gospel he preached among the Gentiles. The leaders added nothing to him. Titus, though a Greek, was not compelled to be circumcised. James, Cephas, and John gave Paul and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship, agreeing that Paul was to go to the Gentiles and they to the circumcised, asking only that they remember the poor.

Then the confrontation at Antioch. Peter had eaten with Gentile believers, but when certain men came from James, he drew back and separated himself, fearing the circumcision party. Even Barnabas was led astray. Paul opposed Peter to his face, because his conduct was not in step with the truth of the gospel. This is the principle: the gospel governs how we live together, and it applies even to apostles.

The center of the chapter is 2:15 to 21. “A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ.” Paul says this three times in a single verse. Then the personal confession: “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives

in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." This is the verse of the unit. Christ's death is my death; his life is my life. And Paul concludes: to go back to the law is to say that Christ died for no purpose. The cross either is enough or it is nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 1:16-17 and 3:21-31 explain the same gospel at greater length. Acts 9:1-30, 15:1-35, and 11:27-30 are the background. Genesis 12:3 and 15:6 stand behind chapter 3. Philippians 3:2-9 repeats the warning against confidence in the flesh. 2 Corinthians 11:4 speaks of a different gospel. 1 Timothy 1:15 shows the heart of the gospel. 1 Corinthians 15:1-11 gives its content. Ephesians 2:8-10 sums up salvation by grace.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Galatians 2:20. Say it each morning this week.

Ask whether you are adding anything to Christ as a requirement for acceptance with God or with his people.

Pray for courage to speak up as Paul did when the gospel is at stake.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel of grace.

Ask him to keep you from any other gospel.

Thank Jesus for giving himself for your sins.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 754 · WEEK 108

Romans 8:14-17; Galatians 4:1-7; 1 John 3:1-3

Adoption

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:14-17, Galatians 4:1-7, and 1 John 3:1-3. Today is a doctrinal pause on adoption. Notice who does the adopting, what the Spirit cries, and what the adopted child receives.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Adoption was a familiar practice in the Roman world. A wealthy family without a suitable heir could adopt a son, who then gained the full rights of the family name and inheritance. Paul uses this to explain what God has done for believers. We were not born children of God in the full covenant sense; we were slaves, and God brought us into his family at great cost. John, the apostle of love, marvels at the same fact.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Romans 8:14).
2. “You have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, Abba! Father!” (Romans 8:15).
3. “And if children, then heirs, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ” (Romans 8:17).
4. “But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons” (Galatians 4:4-5).
5. “And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba! Father!” (Galatians 4:6).

6. “So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God” (Galatians 4:7).
7. “See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are” (1 John 3:1).
8. “Beloved, we are God’s children now” (1 John 3:2).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Adoption is the act of God by which he receives believers into his family as his sons and daughters, with all the rights and privileges that belong to children. It is one of the richest images of salvation. Justification answers the question, “How can I be declared right before the Judge?” Adoption answers the question, “How can I be welcomed by the Father?” The two go together. Justification gives us a legal standing; adoption gives us a family and a Father.

Notice the Trinity at work. The Father sends the Son “in the fullness of time” to redeem those under the law. The Son becomes man, born of woman, born under the law, so that he can redeem. The Spirit is sent into our hearts, and he teaches us to cry “Abba! Father!” The word Abba is the Aramaic word of a child to his father, an intimate word that Jesus himself used in Gethsemane (Mark 14:36). Through Christ we share his relationship with the Father.

Adoption has present and future dimensions. Now we are God’s children, and we have the Spirit, access to the Father, his discipline, his care, and his promises. But Paul also says we “wait eagerly for adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies” (Romans 8:23). Our full inheritance, the resurrection and the new creation, is still to come. John says, “What we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we will be like him.”

Adoption is the answer to many fears. The fear of rejection: God has chosen you. The fear of earning: a child does not earn his place. The fear of being alone: the Father is near. And the fear of failing: a child may fail, but remains a child. It also shapes our life together: if we have one Father, we are brothers and sisters. Christians who struggle with the idea of God as Father, because of a human father who failed them, can find that God is the Father they always needed.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Galatians 4 begins with an illustration. An heir, as long as he is a child, is no different from a slave, though he is the owner of everything. He is under guardians until the date set by his father. So we, when we were children, were enslaved to the elementary principles of the world. “But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son.” The timing was

God's. He sent his Son "born of woman, born under the law." The Son took on humanity and submitted to the law. The purpose: "to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

Then the Spirit: "And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba! Father!" The Spirit is the Spirit of the Son; when he lives in us, he leads us to pray as the Son prays. Prayer is the family voice. "So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God."

Romans 8 gives the same truth in the setting of suffering. The Spirit does not make us slaves again to fall back into fear, but sons. "The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him." We share his sufferings now and his glory later.

1 John 3:1 sounds like a gasp of wonder: "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are." The love is not just a feeling; it is something given, an action. And the "so we are" is a guarantee. The world does not recognize us, because it did not know him. But the hope is certain: when he appears, we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And "everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure." The hope of the family inheritance motivates holy living.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 14:36 records Jesus praying "Abba, Father." Matthew 6:9 begins the Lord's Prayer with "Our Father." John 1:12-13 says to all who believed he gave the right to become children of God. Ephesians 1:5 speaks of predestination to adoption. Hebrews 12:5-11 speaks of the Father's discipline. Romans 8:23 and 9:4 speak of adoption. 2 Corinthians 6:18 quotes the promise "I will be a father to you." Luke 15:11-32 shows the Father's welcome. Revelation 21:7 says the one who conquers will have this heritage.

STEP 6

Application

Pray "Abba, Father" today and let yourself feel what it means.

If you struggle with the word "Father," tell God honestly. Ask him to show you what a true Father is.

Treat a fellow believer today as a brother or sister, not an acquaintance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for sending his Son to redeem you so that you could be adopted.
- Pray, “Abba, Father,” and tell him what it means.
- Thank him that you are an heir.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 755 · WEEK 108

Galatians 3:1-4:31

The law as guardian; sons not slaves; Hagar and Sarah

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 3:1-4:31. This long reading is Paul's theological argument. Notice his use of Abraham and the promise, the purpose of the law, and the allegory of Hagar and Sarah. Pay special attention to 3:23-29.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has shown in chapters 1 and 2 that the gospel does not come from men, and that justification is not by works of the law. Now he turns to argue from Scripture and experience. He appeals first to the Galatians' own experience of receiving the Spirit, then to Abraham, then to the purpose of the law. He answers a question the false teachers raised: if the law doesn't justify, why was it given?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you?" (3:1).
2. "Now it is evident that no one is justified before God by the law, for The righteous shall live by faith" (3:11).
3. "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us" (3:13).
4. "So then, the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith" (3:24).
5. "There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus" (3:28).
6. "And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise" (3:29).

7. “My little children, for whom I am again in the anguish of childbirth until Christ is formed in you” (4:19).

8. “Now you, brothers, like Isaac, are children of promise” (4:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a rebuke and a question: “O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you? It was before your eyes that Jesus Christ was publicly portrayed as crucified.” Then he asks: “Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law or by hearing with faith?” They received the Spirit when they first believed, by faith, not by works. Why think they will be perfected by the flesh?

Next Abraham: “Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.” So the sons of Abraham are those of faith. Scripture foresaw that God would justify the Gentiles by faith and preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham: “In you shall all the nations be blessed.” Those who rely on works of the law are under a curse, for it is written, “Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.” No one does. But “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us.” The cross is where the curse fell. This was so that the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, and we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

The law came 430 years after the promise and cannot annul it. If the inheritance comes by law, it no longer comes by promise, but God gave it to Abraham by promise. “Why then the law?” It was added because of transgressions, until the offspring should come. It was a temporary measure. It does not contradict the promises, but it could not give life. “So then, the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith. But now that faith has come, we are no longer under a guardian.” The guardian (Greek paidagogos) was a slave who supervised a child, not a teacher. His job ended when the child grew up. This is a key text for understanding the relationship between the covenants: the Mosaic covenant had a temporary role in God’s plan, and Christ has brought its fulfillment. Christians differ over how much of the law continues to apply as moral guidance; all agree that it is not a means of justification, and that Christ fulfills it.

Then comes one of the greatest statements about the church: “For in Christ Jesus you are all sons of God, through faith. For as many of you as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ. There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus. And if you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring, heirs according to promise.” All the divisions that separated people are overcome. Every believer has the same standing and the same inheritance. This does not erase all distinctions, but it removes them as grounds for status before God.

Chapter 4 continues with adoption (see yesterday's pause) and Paul's pastoral heart: "My little children, for whom I am again in the anguish of childbirth until Christ is formed in you." Then the allegory of Hagar and Sarah. Hagar represents the covenant from Mount Sinai, bearing children for slavery, corresponding to the present Jerusalem. Sarah represents the free woman, the Jerusalem above. "Now you, brothers, like Isaac, are children of promise." The one born according to the flesh persecuted the one born by the Spirit, and so it is now. But "what does the Scripture say? Cast out the slave woman and her son." We are not children of the slave but of the free woman.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:1-3, 15:1-6, and 17 are the Abrahamic covenant. Exodus 19 to 20 is Sinai. Deuteronomy 27:26 and 21:23 are cited in 3:10 and 3:13. Habakkuk 2:4 is cited in 3:11. Genesis 16 and 21 tell of Hagar and Sarah. Isaiah 54:1 is cited in 4:27. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Romans 4 gives a parallel argument. Hebrews 8 to 10 explain the old and new covenants. Colossians 2:16-17 says the old is a shadow and the substance belongs to Christ. Revelation 21:2 speaks of the new Jerusalem.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are trying to be perfected by the flesh after beginning in the Spirit.

Thank Christ for becoming a curse for you. Say it slowly.

Seek out someone different from you, in age, background, or status, and show them the unity we have in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Christ for becoming a curse for you.
- Thank him that you are a son or daughter and not a slave.
- Ask him to teach you to live in that freedom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 756 · WEEK 108

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Galatians 4:4-5 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

REST

Meditation

Four phrases carry the verse.

"When the fullness of time had come." History is not random. God had been preparing for centuries, through Abraham, Moses, David, and the prophets, until the moment he chose. The coming of Christ was right on schedule.

"God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law." The Son existed before he was sent. He was born of a woman, fully human, and born under the law, placing himself under the obligations of God's covenant with Israel. He lived the life we should have lived.

"To redeem those who were under the law." Redemption means buying back, the price paid to free a slave. He kept the law that we broke and bore the curse that we deserved.

“So that we might receive adoption as sons.” The goal is not just freedom, but family. We are not simply released; we are welcomed home.

Whenever you feel like a stranger or an orphan, say this verse. You were bought at a price in order to be brought home.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the unit on law, gospel, and the church by reading Galatians, Paul’s urgent defense of the gospel. In Galatians 1 and 2 you saw that there is no other gospel, that Paul’s message came by revelation, and that he opposed Peter at Antioch because the gospel is at stake in how we live together. In a doctrinal pause on adoption, you saw how the Father sent the Son and the Spirit so that sinners could become sons and daughters and cry “Abba! Father!” In Galatians 3 and 4, you read the case from Scripture: Abraham was justified by faith, Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law, the law was a temporary guardian, and in Christ all are sons and heirs. You also saw Paul’s allegory of Hagar and Sarah, with the contrast between slavery and freedom.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says the gospel cannot be added to. Is there anything you tend to add to faith in Christ as a requirement for being accepted by God, such as performance, a feeling, or a ritual? How does the cross answer that?

Galatians 3:13 says Christ became a curse for us. How does it affect you to know that Jesus took the curse that belonged to you? What does this make you want to say to him?

Which is harder for you to believe: that you are forgiven, or that you are a beloved son or daughter of the Father? What might help you rest in your adoption this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son to redeem and adopt you.

Rest as his child.

Ask him to quiet any fear of not belonging.

DAY 757 · WEEK 109

Galatians 5:1-6:18

Christian freedom; the fruit of the Spirit; the new creation

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 5:1-6:18. Paul moves from the doctrine of freedom to its practice. Notice the contrast between flesh and Spirit, the fruit of the Spirit, and the closing summary about the cross and new creation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has argued that we are justified by faith, not law. But does this freedom lead to a life of license? The opposite error was also a danger. In chapters 5 and 6, Paul shows how freedom works: we are called to freedom, but we use it to serve others in love, and we live by the Spirit who produces holiness. This is one of the best summaries of the Christian life in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery" (5:1).
2. "For you were called to freedom, brothers. Only do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh, but through love serve one another" (5:13).
3. "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh" (5:16).
4. "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law" (5:22-23).
5. "Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ" (6:2).
6. "And let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap, if we do not give up" (6:9).

7. “Far be it from me to boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world” (6:14).

8. “For neither circumcision counts for anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creation” (6:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery.” Paul warns that if the Galatians accept circumcision as a means of righteousness, Christ will be of no advantage to them, and they are obligated to keep the whole law. “You are severed from Christ, you who would be justified by the law; you have fallen away from grace.” In Christ Jesus, what counts is “faith working through love.”

Then the other danger: “You were called to freedom, brothers. Only do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh, but through love serve one another. For the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself.” Freedom from the law is not freedom from love. It is freedom to love. “But if you bite and devour one another, watch out that you are not consumed by one another.”

The solution is the Spirit. “Walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do.” This is the war within every believer. The “works of the flesh” are obvious: sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality, idolatry, sorcery, enmity, strife, jealousy, fits of anger, rivalries, dissensions, divisions, envy, drunkenness, orgies. Those who do such things will not inherit the kingdom of God. Notice how many involve relationships.

In contrast, “the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control.” The singular “fruit” suggests one character with nine facets. It is the character of Christ. It grows; it is not manufactured. We cannot produce fruit by effort alone, but by abiding. And “those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. If we live by the Spirit, let us also keep in step with the Spirit.”

Chapter 6 gives practical instructions: restore gently someone caught in a transgression, watching yourself lest you too be tempted. “Bear one another’s burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.” Each must also bear his own load (the daily responsibility). Share good things with those who teach. “Do not be deceived: God is not mocked, for whatever one sows, that will he also reap.” Sowing to the Spirit leads to eternal life. “Let us not grow weary of doing good.”

Paul takes the pen in his own hand to write the closing in large letters. His boast is not in circumcision or any achievement. “Far be it from me to boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world. For neither circumcision counts for anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creation.” The cross is the center, and the new creation is the goal. “Peace and mercy be upon all who walk by this rule, upon the Israel of God.” Interpreters differ about whether “the Israel of God” means the church, composed of Jews and Gentiles, or believing Jews within the church. In a progressive covenantal reading, it points to the one people of God, united in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 6 to 8 expands the same themes of freedom and the Spirit. Leviticus 19:18 is quoted in 5:14. John 15:1-17 shows fruit through abiding. Ephesians 4:1-6:20 and Colossians 3:1-17 give related moral teaching. Matthew 7:15-20 says a tree is known by its fruit. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of new creation. Isaiah 65:17 and Revelation 21:5 promise all things new. Hebrews 12:1 calls us to lay aside weights. 1 Corinthians 2:2 shows Paul’s focus on the cross.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one fruit of the Spirit that you most need this week. Ask for it, and look for a place to practice it.

Ask whom you can help carry a burden. Do it quietly.

Put your name in 6:14. What do you boast in besides the cross?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for setting you free, and ask him to keep you from returning to slavery.
- Ask the Spirit to produce his fruit in you.
- Tell him which fruit you most need.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 758 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16

The foolishness of the cross; wisdom from above

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16. Paul begins his letter to a gifted but divided church. Notice how he answers pride and division with the cross. Pay particular attention to 1:18-31 and 2:1-5.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Corinth was a wealthy, cosmopolitan port city in Greece, known for commerce, sensuality, and a love of rhetoric. Paul planted the church around AD 50 during an eighteen-month stay (Acts 18). By AD 55 he writes from Ephesus in response to reports and a letter from the church. They had problems: factions around favorite leaders, moral scandal, lawsuits, confusion about marriage, abuse of the Lord's Supper, disorder in worship, and doubts about the resurrection. First Corinthians is a letter for a messy church, and so it is very relevant. Paul's answer to every problem is Christ and him crucified.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God" (1:18).
2. "We preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles" (1:23).
3. "For the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men" (1:25).
4. "He is the source of your life in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1:30).
5. "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord" (1:31).

6. “For I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified” (2:2).
7. “These things God has revealed to us through the Spirit” (2:10).
8. “But we have the mind of Christ” (2:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul greets the church as “sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints.” Despite their failings, they belong to God. He thanks God for the grace given them: they are enriched in speech and knowledge, lacking in no gift, waiting for the revealing of Christ. Then he turns to the first problem: quarrels. “I appeal to you, brothers... that all of you agree, and that there be no divisions among you.” Some said, “I follow Paul,” others, “I follow Apollos,” others Cephas, others Christ. “Is Christ divided? Was Paul crucified for you?”

His answer is the cross. “The word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.” The world seeks signs and wisdom, but “we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles, but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.” The message that seems weak and foolish is God’s chosen method. “The foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men.”

Look at who you are, he says. Not many were wise, powerful, or of noble birth. “God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise; God chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong.” So that no one might boast in the presence of God. “He is the source of your life in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption.” Christ is everything. “Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord.”

In chapter 2, Paul describes his own ministry. He did not come with lofty speech or wisdom. “I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified.” He came in weakness and much trembling, and his message was not in plausible words of wisdom but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power, “that your faith might not rest in the wisdom of men but in the power of God.”

Yet there is a wisdom to be spoken among the mature: not the wisdom of this age, but God’s secret and hidden wisdom, decreed before the ages for our glory. None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory. It is revealed through the Spirit, who searches everything, even the depths of God. “No one comprehends the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God.” We have received the Spirit, so that we might understand the gifts freely given to us.

“The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned.” This explains why people without the Spirit find the gospel foolish. And the chapter ends with a wonderful statement: “But we have the mind of Christ.” By the Spirit, believers can think God’s thoughts after him through his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:14 and Jeremiah 9:23-24 are quoted in chapter 1. Acts 18:1-18 tells of the founding of the church. Isaiah 64:4 and 40:13 are quoted in chapter 2. Galatians 6:14 is a parallel boast in the cross. Philippians 2:1-11 speaks of the mind of Christ. John 16:13-15 promises the Spirit who guides into truth. Romans 1:16 and Colossians 2:2-3 speak of Christ as the center. 1 Peter 2:4-8 says Christ is a stone of stumbling. Ephesians 1:17-18 prays for the Spirit of wisdom.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you are boasting in a leader, a ministry, or a tradition more than in Christ. Replace the boast.

Pray for the Spirit to illumine a passage as you read Scripture this week.

If you feel weak or foolish in the world’s eyes, remember that God chose the weak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the foolishness of the cross that saves you.
- Ask him to keep your eyes on Christ crucified.
- Tell him where you are tempted to rely on human wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 759 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21

The church as God's field; apostolic ministry

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21. Paul continues to deal with divisions by showing how God sees ministers and the church. Notice the pictures: a field, a building, a temple. Notice also what Paul says about being a steward.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that the cross confounds human wisdom. Now he applies this to the church's attitude to its leaders. The Corinthians were comparing teachers like sports fans choosing favorite athletes. Paul wants them to see that ministers are servants and that the church is God's own possession.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth" (3:6).
2. "For no one can lay a foundation other than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ" (3:11).
3. "Do you not know that you are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you?" (3:16).
4. "And you are Christ's, and Christ is God's" (3:23).
5. "This is how one should regard us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God" (4:1).
6. "Moreover, it is required of stewards that they be found faithful" (4:2).
7. "What do you have that you did not receive?" (4:7).
8. "For the kingdom of God does not consist in talk but in power" (4:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says he could not address them as spiritual people but as people of the flesh, infants in Christ. They were still being fed milk. Their jealousy and strife showed it. “For when one says, I follow Paul, and another, I follow Apollos, are you not being merely human?” Then he gives the right view of ministry: “What then is Apollos? What is Paul? Servants through whom you believed, as the Lord assigned to each. I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God who gives the growth.” Ministers are workers; God is the source of life.

The church is “God’s field, God’s building.” Paul laid a foundation as a wise master builder, and others build on it. “No one can lay a foundation other than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.” Each builder must take care how he builds. The quality of each person’s work will be revealed on the day of judgment, tested by fire. Gold, silver, and precious stones endure; wood, hay, and straw burn. If the work survives, the builder receives a reward; if it is burned up, he suffers loss, though he himself will be saved, as through fire. This passage encourages teachers and builders to serve with care, building with the truth.

Then: “Do you not know that you are God’s temple and that God’s Spirit dwells in you? If anyone destroys God’s temple, God will destroy him. For God’s temple is holy, and you are that temple.” Notice that “you” is plural. The church is the dwelling of God’s Spirit. Dividing the church is a serious sin because it damages God’s temple.

Paul urges them to be wise by becoming fools in the world’s eyes, “for the wisdom of this world is folly with God.” And do not boast in men. “For all things are yours, whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas or the world or life or death or the present or the future, all are yours, and you are Christ’s, and Christ is God’s.” The church does not belong to its leaders; the leaders belong to the church, and the church belongs to Christ.

In chapter 4, Paul describes true ministers as “servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God.” A steward manages what belongs to another, and he must be faithful. Paul does not worry about human judgment, or even his own self-assessment: “It is the Lord who judges me.” He gives a sharp contrast between the proud Corinthians, who think themselves kings, and the apostles, who are “a spectacle to the world,” “fools for Christ’s sake,” hungry and homeless, reviled and slandered. “What do you have that you did not receive? If then you received it, why do you boast as if you had not received it?” He closes as a father: “I became your father in Christ Jesus through the gospel.” And he warns that he will come, if the Lord wills, to see not the talk but the power.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 28:16 speaks of the cornerstone. Ephesians 2:19-22 says the church is a holy temple in the Lord. 1 Peter 2:4-10 describes living stones. Matthew 7:24-27 shows building on the rock. 2 Corinthians 6:16 repeats that we are the temple of the living God. 1 Timothy 3:15 calls the church the pillar and buttress of the truth. Luke 12:42-48 describes the faithful steward. Romans 11:36 speaks of all things from him. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is a charge to elders.

STEP 6

Application

Thank a person who planted or watered in your life. Remember that God gave the growth.

Ask what you are building with: gold, silver, or straw. How could your ministry or your work last?

Look at your gifts and abilities and ask, What do I have that I did not receive?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he alone gives growth.
- Thank him for those who planted and watered in your life.
- Ask him to make Christ your only foundation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 760 · WEEK 109

Psalm 33

God's word stands; rest in God alone

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33. It is a song of praise that begins in joy and ends in waiting. Notice how the psalm moves from God's creating word to his counsel to the waiting soul, and how it connects to Paul's argument that God's wisdom is greater than the world's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 33 has no title, but it follows Psalm 32 as a joyful response to forgiveness. It is a hymn of praise that celebrates God's word, his creation, and his rule over the nations. In Corinthians, Paul has just been arguing that God's ways overturn the wisdom of the world and its strength. This psalm sings the same truth: kings and armies cannot save, but the LORD can.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the word of the LORD is upright, and all his work is done in faithfulness" (v. 4).
2. "By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host" (v. 6).
3. "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (v. 9).
4. "The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations" (v. 11).
5. "Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!" (v. 12).
6. "Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love" (v. 18).

7. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield” (v. 20).

8. “Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a summons: “Shout for joy in the LORD, O you righteous! Praise befits the upright.” It calls for a new song with skill and loud shouts, and with the harp and the lyre. The reason for praise is the word of the LORD. His word is upright, and all his work is done in faithfulness. He loves righteousness and justice, and the earth is full of his steadfast love.

Then the psalm turns to creation. “By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host.” This echoes Genesis 1, where God speaks and things come to be. “For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm.” The word of God is powerful and effective. In the New Testament, the Word through whom all things were made is Christ (John 1:1-3). And the “breath of his mouth” can also be heard as the Spirit. The whole Trinity is at work in creation.

The word of the LORD is also the plan of history. “The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples. The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations.” Human schemes rise and fall, but God’s purpose stands. This is the same idea as in 1 Corinthians 1: the wisdom of the world will be undone, but God’s wisdom remains. Notice the blessing for the people he has chosen as his heritage: “Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD.”

God sees everything. From heaven he looks down on all the children of man; he fashions the hearts of all and observes all their deeds. The conclusion: “The king is not saved by his great army; a warrior is not delivered by his great strength. The war horse is a false hope for salvation, and by its great might it cannot rescue.” Military power, wealth, and human strength cannot save. The true safety is in the LORD.

“Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love, that he may deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine.” The psalm ends in humility and trust. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield. For our heart is glad in him, because we trust in his holy name.” And the final prayer: “Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you.” Waiting is the posture of faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 shows creation by God's word. John 1:1-3 and Colossians 1:16 say all things were made through Christ. Hebrews 11:3 says the universe was created by the word of God. Psalm 20:7 and 147:10-11 also contrast chariots and horses with God. Isaiah 40:8 says the word of our God will stand forever. Isaiah 46:10 says my counsel shall stand. Proverbs 19:21 contrasts human plans with the LORD's purpose. 1 Corinthians 1:18-31 is the parallel argument.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read this psalm aloud. Give thanks for something the LORD has made.

Name a plan or worry that depends on human strength. Entrust it to God.

Practice waiting on the LORD without rushing to fix things. Say verse 20 as a prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is upright and his counsel stands forever.

Tell him what plans of yours you want to place under his.

Ask him to let his steadfast love be upon you as you hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 761 · WEEK 109

Psalm 62

For God alone my soul waits in silence

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 62. It is a psalm of quiet trust by David. Notice the repeated word “alone” and how it deals with the temptation to trust in people, power, or wealth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 62 is a psalm of David, probably from a time when enemies were plotting against him. It is a calm psalm in the middle of threat. The key word is “alone”: God alone is my rock. In Corinth, believers were tempted to trust in human leaders and human wisdom. This psalm calls us back to rest in God alone.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For God alone my soul waits in silence; from him comes my salvation” (v. 1).
2. “He alone is my rock and my salvation, my fortress; I shall not be greatly shaken” (v. 2).
3. “For God alone, O my soul, wait in silence, for my hope is from him” (v. 5).
4. “On God rests my salvation and my glory; my mighty rock, my refuge is God” (v. 7).
5. “Trust in him at all times, O people; pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us” (v. 8).
6. “Those of low estate are but a breath; those of high estate are a delusion” (v. 9).
7. “If riches increase, set not your heart on them” (v. 10).
8. “Once God has spoken; twice have I heard this: that power belongs to God” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David opens, “For God alone my soul waits in silence; from him comes my salvation.” The Hebrew has a sense of silence and stillness: the soul is quiet before God. He is not silent because he has no words, but because he is resting. “He alone is my rock and my salvation, my fortress; I shall not be greatly shaken.” The word “alone” appears six times in the psalm. It narrows trust to one object.

Then he addresses his enemies: “How long will all of you attack a man to batter him, like a leaning wall, a tottering fence?” They plan to thrust him down from his high position. They take pleasure in falsehood; they bless with their mouths, but inwardly they curse. In the face of this, David speaks to his own soul: “For God alone, O my soul, wait in silence, for my hope is from him.” He repeats verses 1 and 2 almost word for word, with a slight change. In the first, “I shall not be greatly shaken.” In the second, “I shall not be shaken.” His confidence grows as he preaches to himself.

Verse 8 turns outward to the people: “Trust in him at all times, O people; pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us.” Prayer is pouring out the heart. Then David exposes the false refuges: “Those of low estate are but a breath; those of high estate are a delusion; in the balances they go up; they are together lighter than a breath.” People of any rank, high or low, cannot hold up your weight. Neither can wealth: “Put no trust in extortion; set no vain hopes on robbery. If riches increase, set not your heart on them.” Money is not evil, but it is a poor god.

The psalm ends with God’s word: “Once God has spoken; twice have I heard this: that power belongs to God, and that to you, O Lord, belongs steadfast love. For you will render to a man according to his work.” God is both strong and kind. Power without love would be terrifying; love without power would be useless. God has both.

The cross shows both. The power of God is displayed in weakness; the love of God is shown in sacrifice. This is the paradox that Paul preached in Corinth. Rest in God alone, and pour out your heart to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37:7 says be still before the LORD and wait patiently for him. Psalm 46:10 says be still and know that I am God. Isaiah 30:15 says in returning and rest you shall be saved. Lamentations 3:25-26 says it is good to wait quietly. Matthew 6:19-24 warns about treasures and serving two masters. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 addresses the rich. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man with trust in the LORD. Romans 2:6 echoes verse 12. Philippians 4:6-7 speaks of prayer and peace.

STEP 6

Application

Sit in silence for five minutes today. Practice waiting on God alone.

Ask where you are trusting in people, position, or money. Name one and entrust it to God.

Pour out your heart to God in prayer today, without editing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Wait on God in silence for a moment, and then tell him what you hope for.

Thank him that he is your rock and fortress.

Pour out your heart to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 762 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40

Church discipline; lawsuits; marriage and sexuality

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40. This is a long reading on hard topics: sexual sin in the church, lawsuits, sexuality, and marriage. Read it carefully and with humility. Notice that Paul grounds his commands in the gospel: you were washed, you were bought with a price.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul now deals with specific problems reported to him. Chapter 5 concerns a man living in sexual immorality of a kind that even pagans would not tolerate, and the church's proud tolerance of it. Chapter 6 addresses believers suing each other in pagan courts, and sexual sin. Chapter 7 begins his response to the church's letter, "Now concerning the matters about which you wrote," with a long discussion of marriage, singleness, and divorce. Corinth had a reputation for sexual license, and some believers swung to the opposite extreme of asceticism.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (5:7).
2. "For what have I to do with judging outsiders? Is it not those inside the church whom you are to judge?" (5:12).
3. "And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God" (6:11).
4. "Flee from sexual immorality" (6:18).
5. "You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body" (6:19-20).

6. “Each has his own gift from God, one of one kind and one of another” (7:7).
7. “Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him” (7:17).
8. “You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men” (7:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A man is living with his father’s wife, and the church is arrogant instead of grieving. Paul tells them to remove him from their fellowship, “to deliver this man to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord.” Church discipline has a redemptive goal. He uses the picture of leaven: “a little leaven leavens the whole lump.” And the gospel is the basis: “Cleanse out the old leaven that you may be a new lump, as you really are unleavened. For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed.” The church is to be what it already is in Christ. Paul distinguishes judgment of those inside the church from those outside; God judges outsiders.

In chapter 6, Paul rebukes believers who take each other to court before unbelievers. “Do you not know that the saints will judge the world?” Surely they can settle ordinary matters. It is better to be wronged. Then he lists the unrighteous who will not inherit the kingdom of God: the sexually immoral, idolaters, adulterers, men who practice homosexuality, thieves, the greedy, drunkards, revilers, swindlers. “And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.” The words “such were some of you” are among the most hopeful in the Bible. No one is beyond the reach of the gospel, and no one is allowed to stay as they were.

Paul rejects the slogan “All things are lawful for me.” Not all things are helpful. The body is not for sexual immorality but for the Lord, and the Lord for the body. God raised the Lord and will raise us. Our bodies are members of Christ. “Flee from sexual immorality. Every other sin a person commits is outside the body, but the sexually immoral person sins against his own body.” Then: “Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body.” This is the basis for Christian ethics: we belong to Christ, body and soul.

In chapter 7, Paul addresses marriage and singleness. Marriage is good, and sexual relations within marriage are a duty and a gift, to be mutual. He speaks of his own singleness as a gift: “Each has his own gift from God, one of one kind and one of another.” To the married he gives the Lord’s command that a wife should not separate from her husband, nor a husband divorce his wife. If a believer has an unbelieving spouse who is willing to stay, they should stay. “But if the unbelieving partner separates, let it be so. In such cases the brother or sister

is not enslaved." Christians differ on what this means for divorce and remarriage: some hold that 7:15 allows remarriage after desertion, and others hold stricter or looser positions. Pastoral care and prayer are essential.

The chapter has a repeated principle: "Let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him." Whether married, single, circumcised, or slave, we serve the Lord where he has placed us. Paul urges single believers to consider the advantage of undivided devotion, but this is a counsel, not a command. And "the appointed time has grown very short." The form of this world is passing away. Hold earthly relationships with an eye on eternity.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 18:8 and Deuteronomy 22:30 forbid the sin in chapter 5. Exodus 12 describes the Passover. Matthew 18:15-20 gives the process of discipline. 2 Corinthians 2:5-11 may describe the repentance of this man. Genesis 2:24 is quoted in 6:16. Ephesians 5:22-33 speaks of marriage as Christ and the church. Matthew 19:1-12 is Jesus' teaching on divorce and singleness. Hebrews 13:4 honors marriage. Romans 6:1-14 and 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8 teach holiness. Daniel 7:22 says the saints will judge.

STEP 6

Application

Say 6:11 aloud and put your name in it. You were washed, sanctified, and justified.

Ask where you belong to yourself instead of Christ. Offer your body to him.

If you are single or married, ask God to show you how to serve him fully where you are. Pray for someone in a hard marriage.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being your Passover lamb.
- Thank him that you were washed, sanctified, and justified.
- Ask him to help you flee what harms you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 763 · WEEK 109

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 1:18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

REST

Meditation

Paul writes this verse to a church that was dazzled by wisdom and rhetoric.

"The word of the cross." The gospel is a message about a crucifixion. In the ancient world, crucifixion was the most shameful death, reserved for slaves and rebels. To say that God's salvation came through a crucified man sounded insane.

"Is folly to those who are perishing." To those who are on the way to destruction, the message looks like nonsense. This is not because the message is irrational, but because sin has darkened understanding. Without the Spirit, no one sees its glory.

"But to us who are being saved." The present tense describes an ongoing process: we are being saved, as the Spirit applies the gospel to our lives. The verse divides humanity into two groups, and the dividing line is the cross.

“It is the power of God.” What looks like weakness is strength. The cross is not just the means of forgiveness but the power that changes lives, raises the dead, and breaks the grip of sin.

If you are ever embarrassed by the gospel, say this verse. The message you carry is the power of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Galatians and began 1 Corinthians. Galatians 5 and 6 showed how freedom in Christ works: through love, by walking in the Spirit, producing the fruit of the Spirit, bearing one another’s burdens, and boasting in nothing but the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. First Corinthians opened with a divided, gifted church, and Paul answered every division with the word of the cross, the power and wisdom of God. You studied the church as God’s field, building, and temple, with ministers as servants and stewards. Two psalms taught trust: Psalm 33, the counsel of the LORD stands forever, and Psalm 62, for God alone my soul waits in silence. In chapters 5 to 7, Paul dealt with sexual sin, lawsuits, and marriage, always grounding his commands in the gospel: you were washed, sanctified, and justified, and you were bought with a price.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says the message of the cross seems foolish to the world. Where do you feel pressure to make the gospel more impressive or more respectable? What would it look like to trust the cross itself?

First Corinthians 6:11 says “such were some of you” but you were washed, sanctified, and justified. How does this verse change the way you see your past, and the way you see those who are far from God?

Psalm 62 says “For God alone my soul waits in silence.” What is one thing you tend to rely on besides God alone? What would it look like to wait on him this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that the word of the cross is the power of God.

Thank him that you are being saved.

Rest in what he has done.

DAY 764 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33

Christian freedom; idolatry; love limits liberty

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 95 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33. These three chapters answer a question about food offered to idols. Read for the principle: how do Christians use their freedom? Notice Paul's own example in chapter 9, the warning from Israel in chapter 10, and the closing command in 10:31.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Much of the meat sold in Corinth had first been offered to idols in pagan temples. Some believers said that since idols are nothing, eating that meat was fine. Others, who had been idol worshipers, felt that eating it was a return to idolatry. Paul does not simply side with the strong. He offers principles of knowledge, love, freedom, and warning that apply well beyond food. Typical situations today include entertainment, drinking, holidays, and cultural practices.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This knowledge puffs up, but love builds up" (8:1).
2. "Yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist" (8:6).
3. "For though I am free from all, I have made myself a servant to all, that I might win more of them" (9:19).
4. "I have become all things to all people, that by all means I might save some" (9:22).
5. "And all drank the same spiritual drink. For they were drinking from the spiritual Rock that followed them, and the Rock was Christ" (10:4).

6. “Now these things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction, on whom the end of the ages has come” (10:11).
7. “God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability” (10:13).
8. “So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God” (10:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul starts with a general principle: “Knowledge puffs up, but love builds up.” It is possible to be right and unloving. He agrees with the strong in doctrine: “An idol has no real existence, and there is no God but one.” The great confession of 8:6 echoes the Shema: “For us there is one God, the Father… and one Lord, Jesus Christ.” Paul places Jesus within the identity of the one God. Yet not everyone has this knowledge, and a weaker conscience may be defiled. “Take care that this right of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak.” Love limits liberty: “If food is a cause of my brother’s stumbling, I will never eat meat, lest I cause my brother to stumble.”

In chapter 9, Paul uses himself as an example. He is an apostle with rights: to eat and drink, to be married, to be supported by the churches, as the Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel get their living by the gospel. “But I have made no use of any of these rights.” He renounces them to avoid putting an obstacle in the way of the gospel. “For though I am free from all, I have made myself a servant to all, that I might win more of them.” To the Jews he became as a Jew; to those under the law as under the law; to those outside the law as outside the law, though not outside the law of God; to the weak, weak. “I have become all things to all people, that by all means I might save some. I do it all for the sake of the gospel.” Paul adapts his behavior, not his message. Then he compares the Christian life to a race and to boxing, with self-discipline and an imperishable crown.

Chapter 10 warns from Israel’s history. All were baptized into Moses in the cloud and the sea, all ate the same spiritual food and drank the same spiritual drink, “for they were drinking from the spiritual Rock that followed them, and the Rock was Christ.” Yet with most of them God was not pleased, and they were overthrown in the wilderness. Idolatry, immorality, testing the Lord, and grumbling brought judgment. “These things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction, on whom the end of the ages has come. Therefore let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall.” This is a key text for reading the Old Testament as Christian Scripture: Christ was present in Israel’s story, and its lessons are for us.

And then comfort: “No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability, but with the temptation he will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it.” The instruction is to

flee idolatry. The Lord's Supper is a participation in the blood and body of Christ, and one cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of demons.

The closing principles in 10:23 to 11:1: not everything is helpful, seek the good of your neighbor, give thanks, and avoid causing offense. "So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God." Give no offense to Jews, Greeks, or the church of God. "Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ."

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 6:4 is the Shema, which Paul reworks in 8:6. Numbers 11, 14, 16, 21, and 25 describe the wilderness failures. Exodus 14 and 17 describe the sea and the rock. Romans 14 to 15 treats a similar question. Acts 15:28-29 and Revelation 2:14, 20 address meat offered to idols. Philippians 3:12-14 and 2 Timothy 4:7 speak of the race. Hebrews 3 to 4 also draw lessons from Israel's wilderness. John 4:34 and Colossians 3:17 speak of doing all for God.

STEP 6

Application

Name a freedom you have that might hinder a friend or new believer. Be willing to give it up for love.

Ask yourself: Does my knowledge puff me up or build up others?

Do one ordinary thing today, eating or working, "to the glory of God" and say so in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the one God and one Lord.

Ask him to keep your knowledge from puffing you up and make you loving.

Ask him to help you give up a liberty if it would help a brother or sister.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

“So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 765 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 11:17-34; Luke 22:14-20; Matthew 26:26-29

The Sacraments, The Lord's Supper

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 11:17-34, Luke 22:14-20, and Matthew 26:26-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Lord's Supper. Notice what Jesus said and did, and how Paul corrects the Corinthians' abuse of the meal.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the night he was betrayed, Jesus celebrated the Passover with his disciples and gave them a new meal. From the beginning the church repeated this meal. By the time Paul wrote, it was a regular part of church gatherings. In Corinth, the meal had been corrupted: the rich ate and drank to excess while the poor went hungry, so the meal became a mark of division, not unity. Paul's correction tells us what the Supper is meant to be.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer" (Luke 22:15).
2. "This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me" (Luke 22:19).
3. "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).
4. "For this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28).
5. "I tell you I will not drink again of this fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new with you in my Father's kingdom" (Matthew 26:29).
6. "For as often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes" (1 Corinthians 11:26).

7. “Let a person examine himself, then, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup” (1 Corinthians 11:28).

8. “For anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment on himself” (1 Corinthians 11:29).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Lord’s Supper (also called Communion, the Eucharist, or the Lord’s Table) is the meal in which Christ’s people eat bread and drink the cup in remembrance of his death. Jesus instituted it at the Last Supper, and the church has observed it since the first century. It has several meanings. It looks back: “Do this in remembrance of me.” It proclaims: “You proclaim the Lord’s death.” It looks forward: “until he comes,” and Jesus pointed to the feast in the kingdom. It signifies and seals the new covenant in his blood, the forgiveness of sins. And it signifies our unity: “Because there is one bread, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one bread” (1 Corinthians 10:17).

Christians have disagreed about how Christ is present in the Supper, and this is one of the major differences between traditions. Roman Catholics hold that the bread and wine become the body and blood of Christ (transubstantiation). Lutherans hold that Christ’s body and blood are truly present “in, with, and under” the elements. Reformed Christians (following Calvin) hold that Christ is truly present by the Spirit, and the believer feeds on him by faith, though not physically in the elements. Many Baptists and others hold that the Supper is primarily a memorial and proclamation, an ordinance in which Christ is remembered. Traditions also differ on who may partake, how often, and who may administer. These matters deserve serious study and respect for one another.

What all agree on is that the Supper is a gift of grace for believers and a means of strengthening faith. It is to be approached with self-examination, not to earn forgiveness but to repent, trust, and be reconciled. It is to be shared in a way that honors the unity of the body. And it points beyond itself: the table is a foretaste of the wedding supper of the Lamb.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Luke 22, Jesus says, “I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.” He knew what lay ahead and still longed for fellowship with his friends. The Passover meal remembered God’s rescue of Israel from Egypt, with the blood of a lamb protecting the firstborn. Jesus takes the bread, gives thanks, breaks it, and says, “This is my body, which is given for you.” After supper he takes the cup: “This cup that is poured out for you is the new

covenant in my blood." Matthew adds, "for the forgiveness of sins." He is the Lamb, and his blood establishes the new covenant that Jeremiah promised (31:31-34). And he looks ahead: he will not drink again until he drinks it new in the kingdom.

In 1 Corinthians 11, Paul first rebukes the divisions at the meal: "When you come together, it is not the Lord's supper that you eat. For in eating, each one goes ahead with his own meal. One goes hungry, another gets drunk." They were humiliating the poor. Then he recalls what he received from the Lord: Jesus on the night he was betrayed took bread, gave thanks, broke it, and said, "This is my body which is for you. Do this in remembrance of me." Likewise the cup. The Supper is a proclamation of the Lord's death.

Paul warns: "Whoever, therefore, eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty concerning the body and blood of the Lord." The "unworthy manner" refers to how they ate, with contempt for the poor, not that the person is unworthy, since no one is worthy in himself. "Let a person examine himself, then." We examine our hearts and our relationships. Some had become weak, ill, or had died, as a disciplinary judgment from the Lord, "that we may not be condemned along with the world." It is a sober reminder. The right response is not to avoid the table but to come repentant and in unity: "When you come together to eat, wait for one another."

Taking the Supper is one of the plainest ways the gospel is displayed. We do not make the meal; we receive it. We do not offer a sacrifice; we receive the benefits of the one sacrifice. And we eat together, which shows that we are one family.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 describes the Passover. Exodus 24:8 speaks of the blood of the covenant. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. John 6:22-59 is Jesus' bread of life discourse. 1 Corinthians 10:14-22 speaks of participation. Isaiah 25:6-8 pictures the feast on the mountain. Revelation 19:6-9 describes the marriage supper of the Lamb. Acts 2:42 and 20:7 show the early church breaking bread. Hebrews 9:11-10:18 explains the once-for-all sacrifice. Matthew 5:23-24 speaks of reconciliation before worship.

STEP 6

Application

Before your next Communion, spend time examining your heart. Ask whether you are at peace with others.

Read the words of institution slowly and picture the upper room.

Pray for unity in your church and for those in your church who are poor or left out.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for the bread and the cup.
- Ask him to teach you to come to his table with reverence and joy.
- Ask him to remind you of his death until he comes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 766 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 11:1-34

Head coverings; the Lord's Supper

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 11:1-34. The chapter has two parts: guidance on worship conduct (verses 2-16) and the Lord's Supper (verses 17-34). You read about the Supper yesterday. Today give attention to verses 2-16, which are some of the hardest in the letter to interpret, and read them with humility.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul begins a new section on public worship. He first praises them for remembering him and holding to the traditions as he delivered them. Then he addresses a problem in worship that involved how men and women dressed or wore their hair when praying or prophesying. The details of the first-century practice are not entirely clear to us, which is why interpreters have differed for centuries. What is clear is that both men and women prayed and prophesied in the gathered church, and that Paul cared about order and about honoring Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ" (11:1).
2. "Nevertheless, in the Lord woman is not independent of man nor man of woman" (11:11).
3. "If anyone is inclined to be contentious, we have no such practice, nor do the churches of God" (11:16).
4. "When you come together as a church, I hear that there are divisions among you" (11:18).
5. "Each one goes ahead with his own meal. One goes hungry, another gets drunk" (11:21).

6. “For I received from the Lord what I also delivered to you” (11:23).
7. “This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me” (11:25).
8. “When you come together to eat, wait for one another” (11:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens with a command that belongs to the previous section: “Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ.” Then Paul commends them for keeping the traditions. “But I want you to understand that the head of every man is Christ, the head of a wife is her husband, and the head of Christ is God.” The word translated “head” (kephale) is debated. Some understand it as authority, leading to a view that men have a leading role in the home and church. Others understand it as source or origin, since the passage speaks of woman coming from man in creation. Christians who love the Bible land in different places, so we should be gracious.

Paul then gives instructions about heads being covered or uncovered when praying or prophesying. It is likely that the issue was cultural markers of honor and shame in Corinth, and that Paul wanted men and women to present themselves in a way that did not bring disgrace or confusion about the gender distinctions God made. Some churches have taken this passage as requiring head coverings for women today; others see the principle as honoring order and distinction while the specific custom was cultural. Paul himself says, “We have no such practice, nor do the churches of God,” for those who are contentious. What is beyond dispute is verse 11: “In the Lord woman is not independent of man nor man of woman; for as woman was made from man, so man is now born of woman. And all things are from God.” Men and women need one another, and both are from God. And Paul assumes that women pray and prophesy in the assembly.

Verses 17 to 34 return to the Lord’s Supper, which you studied yesterday. Paul says the divisions among them are in a sense necessary “in order that those who are genuine among you may be recognized.” Their meal was becoming a display of status. “Do you despise the church of God and humiliate those who have nothing?” This is a rebuke of the rich who eat first. Paul then recalls the Lord’s own words. The Supper is a proclamation of the cross and a call to unity.

Self-examination and discerning the body (the church) are both required. The weak and sick among them show the seriousness of misusing the meal. Paul’s practical conclusion is simple: “So then, my brothers, when you come together to eat, wait for one another. If anyone is hungry, let him eat at home, so that when you come together it will not be for judgment.”

The big idea of the chapter is that worship is ordered by the gospel. Whatever our practice, it must honor Christ, build up the church, and care for the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:26-27 and 2:18-23 are the creation background. Ephesians 5:21-33 speaks of headship and love. Galatians 3:28 says there is no male and female in Christ. Acts 2:17-18 and 21:9 mention women prophesying. 1 Timothy 2:8-15 also addresses worship. Luke 22:19-20 is the institution of the Supper. 1 Corinthians 10:16-17 speaks of participation. James 2:1-9 warns against partiality toward the rich. Hebrews 13:7 says to imitate the faith of leaders. Philippians 2:3-4 urges us to look to the interests of others.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whom in your church gets overlooked. Wait for them, honor them, and include them.

Pray that your church's worship would reflect the gospel in both order and love.

On a point where Christians disagree, ask how you can listen first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you imitate those who imitate Christ.
- Ask him to order your worship.
- Thank him for making men and women for one another.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 767 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40

Spiritual gifts; one body; love supreme

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40. These three chapters form one argument about spiritual gifts. Read chapter 13 in its place, not in isolation: it sits between two chapters on gifts and explains how they are to be used. Notice the body in chapter 12, love in chapter 13, and order in chapter 14.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Corinthians were eager for spiritual gifts, especially the dramatic ones like tongues. But their use of gifts had become a source of pride, rivalry, and disorder in worship. Paul takes the opportunity to teach about the nature and purpose of the Spirit's gifts. Chapter 13 is not a stand-alone poem on love for weddings, although it is often read there. It is a rebuke and a remedy for a church that valued display over love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "No one can say Jesus is Lord except in the Holy Spirit" (12:3).
2. "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good" (12:7).
3. "For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ" (12:12).
4. "If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together" (12:26).
5. "If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I am a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal" (13:1).
6. "Love is patient and kind; love does not envy or boast; it is not arrogant or rude" (13:4).

7. “So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love” (13:13).

8. “But all things should be done decently and in order” (14:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a test. Pagans were led astray to mute idols. By contrast, “no one speaking in the Spirit of God ever says Jesus is accursed, and no one can say Jesus is Lord except in the Holy Spirit.” Every believer has the Spirit, shown by confessing Christ as Lord. Then comes the Trinity: “There are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; and there are varieties of activities, but it is the same God who empowers them all in everyone.” The gifts are for “the common good,” not for private status. Paul lists wisdom, knowledge, faith, healing, miracles, prophecy, distinguishing of spirits, tongues, and interpretation, all empowered by one and the same Spirit, “who apportions to each one individually as he wills.”

He then pictures the church as a body. “Just as the body is one and has many members… so it is with Christ. For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body, Jews or Greeks, slaves or free.” The foot cannot say it is not part of the body because it is not a hand. The eye cannot say to the hand, “I have no need of you.” God has so composed the body, giving greater honor to the part that lacked it, that there may be no division. “If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together. Now you are the body of Christ and individually members of it.” He lists the offices again: apostles, prophets, teachers, miracle workers, healers, helpers, administrators, tongues. “And I will show you a still more excellent way.”

That way is love. Without it, the most impressive gifts are noise. Tongues, prophecy, knowledge, faith that moves mountains, giving all I have, even martyrdom: “if I have not love, I gain nothing.” Then the description: love is patient and kind; does not envy or boast; is not arrogant or rude; does not insist on its own way; is not irritable or resentful; does not rejoice at wrongdoing, but rejoices with the truth. It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things. Read these as a portrait of Christ, and a mirror for ourselves. “Love never ends.” Prophecies will pass away, tongues will cease, knowledge will vanish. Now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face. “So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

Chapter 14 applies the principle. Pursue love, and desire the spiritual gifts, especially prophecy, because it builds up the church. Tongues, unless interpreted, edify only the speaker. “In church I would rather speak five words with my mind in order to instruct others, than ten thousand words in a tongue.” The aim is building up. Women and men should keep

order: “God is not a God of confusion but of peace.” Verses 34 to 35 on women being silent have been understood in different ways: as a local issue of disruptive questions, as a restriction on weighing prophecy, or as a quotation of a Corinthian slogan. “But all things should be done decently and in order.”

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 2 describes the Spirit at Pentecost. Romans 12:3-8 and Ephesians 4:1-16 also treat gifts and the body. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment of love. Colossians 3:14 says above all put on love. 1 John 4:7-21 says God is love. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Matthew 22:37-40 sums up the law as love. 1 Peter 4:10-11 speaks of using gifts to serve others. Philippians 2:1-4 teaches humility. 2 Corinthians 3:18 and 5:7 speak of seeing now and then.

STEP 6

Application

Read chapter 13 and replace the word “love” with your own name. Where does it not fit? Ask Christ, who does fit, to make it true of you.

Ask what gift God gave you for the common good. Offer it this week.

Honor a member of your church who is less visible, like the weaker parts of the body.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Holy Spirit for giving each believer gifts for the common good.
- Ask him to make you content as part of the body.
- Ask him to make love supreme in your gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

“So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 768 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-16

Spiritual Gifts and the Body of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 12:1-31, Romans 12:3-8, and Ephesians 4:11-16. Today is a doctrinal pause on spiritual gifts and the body of Christ. Notice who gives the gifts, what they are for, and how they work together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three letters, three lists, one body. Paul wrote to Corinth, to Rome, and to Ephesus, each time teaching that every believer has a place in the body of Christ. Today we step back from the details of Corinth to see the overall teaching on gifts. This is also an area where evangelical Christians hold different views, especially about miraculous gifts, so it is important to learn the basics and to treat each other kindly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit” (1 Corinthians 12:4).
2. “To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good” (1 Corinthians 12:7).
3. “All these are empowered by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills” (1 Corinthians 12:11).
4. “The eye cannot say to the hand, I have no need of you” (1 Corinthians 12:21).
5. “Not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think” (Romans 12:3).
6. “Having gifts that differ according to the grace given to us, let us use them” (Romans 12:6).

7. “To equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ” (Ephesians 4:12).

8. “Makes the body grow so that it builds itself up in love” (Ephesians 4:16).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A spiritual gift is a capacity given by the Holy Spirit to a believer for serving others and building up the church. The Greek word is charisma, from charis (grace): a gift of grace. Three truths hold throughout the New Testament. First, gifts are given by the Spirit, not earned. “He apportions to each one individually as he wills.” Second, every believer has at least one gift: “To each is given.” No one is without a role. Third, gifts are for the common good, not personal status. They are tools for service, not trophies.

The lists in the New Testament are not exhaustive. 1 Corinthians 12 includes wisdom, knowledge, faith, healing, miracles, prophecy, discernment, tongues, and interpretation. Romans 12 adds serving, teaching, exhorting, giving, leading, and mercy. Ephesians 4 names gifted people given to the church: apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, and teachers. 1 Peter 4 divides them into speaking and serving gifts. We see that gifts are as varied as the needs of the body.

Christians disagree about some gifts. Continuationists hold that all gifts, including prophecy, healing, and tongues, continue today. Cessationists hold that the miraculous sign gifts and the foundational office of apostle ceased when the New Testament was completed. Others take a position between them, expecting God to work miraculously while being cautious about claims. All agree that the Spirit is active today, that Scripture is the final authority and is complete, that gifts must be tested by the word, and that love is greater than any gift.

The body image is the center of the doctrine. A body has many parts, each necessary, none self-sufficient. The weaker parts are indispensable. The purpose is edification: “to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ,” until we all attain to the unity of the faith and the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood. Pastors and teachers are not to do all the ministry; they equip the saints to do it. The result is a church that grows “in love.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

In 1 Corinthians 12, the foundation is the Trinity: the same Spirit, the same Lord, the same God. Diversity springs from unity. Next, purpose: “for the common good.” A gift that is not shared has missed its purpose. Third, Paul addresses two opposite attitudes. Pride says, “I do

not need you." Inferiority says, "I do not belong." Both are corrected by the body image. If the whole body were an eye, where would be the hearing? God arranged the members as he chose.

Romans 12:3 brings humility: "By the grace given to me I say to everyone among you not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think, but to think with sober judgment, each according to the measure of faith that God has assigned." We have received our gifts; we do not deserve them. Then the diversity: prophecy "in proportion to our faith," service, teaching, exhortation, giving "with generosity," leading "with zeal," mercy "with cheerfulness." Each gift is paired with a way of using it well.

Ephesians 4 shows how Christ is the source: "When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men." Christ gave to the church leaders who equip. "Until we all attain to the unity of the faith… so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine." Instead, "speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ, from whom the whole body, joined and held together by every joint with which it is equipped, when each part is working properly, makes the body grow so that it builds itself up in love."

If you are a believer, you have a gift. Find it by serving in your local church, asking others where they see God's work through you, and trying things. Do not wait for a certainty. You cannot fully know your gift until you use it. And remember the chapter that follows 1 Corinthians 12: without love, even the best gift is nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 6:1-7 shows the church appointing servants. Exodus 31:1-6 speaks of Bezalel being filled with the Spirit for craftsmanship. 1 Peter 4:10-11 speaks of being good stewards of God's varied grace. Psalm 68:18 is quoted in Ephesians 4:8. Colossians 2:19 speaks of the whole body knit together. 1 Thessalonians 5:19-22 says to test everything. 1 Corinthians 14:1-5 compares tongues and prophecy. Hebrews 2:4 mentions gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to his will. Matthew 25:14-30 is the parable of the talents.

STEP 6

Application

Write down the ways you serve your local church now. If you have none, pick one place to start.

Ask two people who know you what they see as your strength in serving others.

Thank someone whose gifts are different from yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Holy Spirit for gifts given to every believer.
- Ask him to show you what you have been given and how to use it.
- Ask him to help you honor others' gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 769 · WEEK 110

Psalm 111

Great are the works of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 111. It is one of the alphabetic acrostic psalms, with each line beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Read it as a hymn of remembering God's works, and notice its link to the Lord's Supper and the church's gathering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 111 and 112 are a pair. Both begin with "Praise the LORD" and are acrostics, each with twenty-two short lines. Psalm 111 describes God and his works; Psalm 112 describes the person who fears him and reflects his character. Psalm 111 is sung in the congregation: "in the company of the upright, in the congregation." It fits our study of the church's worship and the meal of remembrance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart, in the company of the upright, in the congregation" (v. 1).
2. "Great are the works of the LORD, studied by all who delight in them" (v. 2).
3. "Full of splendor and majesty is his work, and his righteousness endures forever" (v. 3).
4. "He has caused his wondrous works to be remembered; the LORD is gracious and merciful" (v. 4).
5. "He provides food for those who fear him; he remembers his covenant forever" (v. 5).
6. "He sent redemption to his people; he has commanded his covenant forever" (v. 9).
7. "Holy and awesome is his name!" (v. 9).

8 “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom; all those who practice it have a good understanding” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with whole-hearted thanksgiving, offered in the congregation. Worship is personal and corporate. Verse 2 says the works of the LORD are great and “studied by all who delight in them.” We are invited not only to admire God’s works but to study them. The more we look, the more we see his splendor and majesty. “His righteousness endures forever.”

Verse 4 is the heart: “He has caused his wondrous works to be remembered; the LORD is gracious and merciful.” God designs memorials. He gave Israel the Passover, the feasts, and the stones of remembrance, and he has given the church the Lord’s Supper. We tend to forget, so God gives us ways to remember. The psalm’s God is “gracious and merciful,” echoing Exodus 34:6. Verse 5: “He provides food for those who fear him; he remembers his covenant forever.” This recalls manna in the wilderness, and our daily bread. Notice that God remembers his covenant, even as he asks us to remember his works.

The next verses speak of power and justice. “He has shown his people the power of his works, in giving them the inheritance of the nations.” “The works of his hands are faithful and just; all his precepts are trustworthy; they are established forever and ever, to be performed with faithfulness and uprightness.” His commands are as reliable as his deeds.

Then the great verse: “He sent redemption to his people; he has commanded his covenant forever. Holy and awesome is his name!” Redemption is the exodus in the original context. For Christians it is also the cross, where the Lord Jesus redeemed us by his blood, establishing the new covenant. The Supper is the memorial of that redemption. And the name of the LORD is holy and awesome (the word is “fearful,” to be revered).

The psalm ends with a proverb that is also the key to the whole Bible’s wisdom literature: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom; all those who practice it have a good understanding. His praise endures forever!” Wisdom begins with reverent awe before the God who has acted. This connects with the opening chapters of 1 Corinthians, where the wisdom of God is found in the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 describes God as gracious and merciful. Exodus 12:14 and Deuteronomy 8:2 speak of remembering. Psalm 105 retells God’s works. Luke 22:19 says “Do this in remembrance of me.” Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 say the fear of the LORD is the beginning of

wisdom. Luke 1:68 and 1:49 speak of redemption and the holy name. Revelation 15:3-4 sings "Great and amazing are your deeds." Psalm 112 is the companion psalm. Hebrews 9:15 speaks of redemption under the new covenant.

STEP 6

Application

Write down three of the LORD's works in your life and give thanks in the congregation of your family or friends.

At your next Communion, pray verse 4: he has caused his wondrous works to be remembered.

Study one of God's works this week, in creation or in Scripture, and delight in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God with your whole heart.
- Tell him about works of his that you want to remember.
- Ask him to give you the fear of the LORD that is the beginning of wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 770 · WEEK 110

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 13:13 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is the last line of the love chapter, and it summarizes a chapter about what lasts.

"So now." Paul has described gifts that will pass away: prophecies, tongues, knowledge. They are temporary scaffolding. "Now" marks the present time between Christ's first and second comings.

"Faith, hope, and love abide." These three remain. Faith trusts God's promises. Hope looks forward to what he has promised. Love gives itself to God and others. Each is a gift of the Spirit, and each is fixed on Christ.

"These three." They go together. Faith without love is dead; hope without faith is wishful; love without hope grows weary. The Christian life is a life of all three.

“But the greatest of these is love.” Why is love greatest? Because faith will become sight, and hope will be fulfilled, but love will last forever. God himself is love. In heaven, we won’t need to believe what we see or hope for what we have, but we will love for all eternity.

When you wonder what matters most in the church or in your life, say this verse. Love is the measure of all.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read more of 1 Corinthians and saw how Paul answered a church’s questions with the gospel. In chapters 8 to 10, you learned how to use freedom: knowledge puffs up but love builds up, and whatever we do we should do for the glory of God. A doctrinal pause on the Lord’s Supper taught that Jesus gave his church a meal of remembrance, proclamation, and hope, and that we come in repentance and unity. In chapter 11, you read about order in worship and the sin of dividing the body at the Lord’s table. Chapters 12 to 14 gave the great teaching on spiritual gifts: one Spirit, many gifts, one body, and the more excellent way of love. A second doctrinal pause considered the gifts and the body of Christ. Psalm 111 called us to remember and give thanks for the works of the LORD, who sent redemption to his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says love is greater than faith and hope. What does it look like to treat love as the most important measure of your spiritual life, and not gifts, knowledge, or activity?

The Lord’s Supper proclaims Christ’s death until he comes. How might you prepare differently the next time you take Communion?

What gift has God given you for the common good of your church? Who in your church needs what you can offer?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the meal of remembrance.

Thank him for gifts he gives his church.

Ask him to teach you to love as he loves.

DAY 771 · WEEK 111

Psalm 112

Blessed is the man who fears the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 112. It is the companion to Psalm 111. Where Psalm 111 described the LORD, this psalm describes the person who fears the LORD, and the person turns out to be like him. Paul quotes verse 9 in 2 Corinthians 9:9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 112 is also an acrostic, with twenty-two short lines. It describes the blessed person who fears the LORD and delights in his commandments. The pairing with Psalm 111 is intentional: many phrases are repeated, like "his righteousness endures forever." What is said of God is also said of the godly person. This is the Bible's picture of becoming like the one we worship. It also anticipates Paul's teaching about generosity at the end of the unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Blessed is the man who fears the LORD, who greatly delights in his commandments!" (v. 1).
2. "Light dawns in the darkness for the upright; he is gracious, merciful, and righteous" (v. 4).
3. "It is well with the man who deals generously and lends; who conducts his affairs with justice" (v. 5).
4. "For the righteous will never be moved; he will be remembered forever" (v. 6).
5. "He is not afraid of bad news; his heart is firm, trusting in the LORD" (v. 7).
6. "His heart is steady; he will not be afraid" (v. 8).
7. "He has distributed freely; he has given to the poor" (v. 9).

8 “His righteousness endures forever; his horn is exalted in honor” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a beatitude: “Blessed is the man who fears the LORD, who greatly delights in his commandments!” Fear and delight go together. The fear of the LORD is not terror but reverence, and obedience is a joy, not a burden. The blessing extends to the next generation: “His offspring will be mighty in the land.” Wealth and righteousness are mentioned, but the focus is on the character that lasts: “his righteousness endures forever.” This is the same phrase used of God in Psalm 111:3. The godly person reflects the character of God.

Verse 4 gives the surprising line: “Light dawns in the darkness for the upright; he is gracious, merciful, and righteous.” Again, the words “gracious and merciful” are used of God in Psalm 111:4. The person who fears the LORD is a light for others in dark times, and he receives light himself. Then comes generosity: “It is well with the man who deals generously and lends; who conducts his affairs with justice.” Faith expresses itself in the use of money and in fairness.

Verse 6 says “The righteous will never be moved; he will be remembered forever.” This echoes the stability of the one who trusts in the LORD. Verse 7: “He is not afraid of bad news; his heart is firm, trusting in the LORD.” How many of us live in fear of bad news? The believer’s security rests on a faithful God, not on good circumstances. This does not mean no bad news will come, but that it cannot shake us. “His heart is steady; he will not be afraid, until he looks in triumph on his adversaries.”

Verse 9 is the center: “He has distributed freely; he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures forever; his horn is exalted in honor.” Paul quotes this verse in 2 Corinthians 9:9 to encourage the Corinthians to give to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Generosity is a sign of righteousness. And God, who supplies seed to the sower, will multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness.

The psalm ends with a contrast: “The wicked man sees it and is angry; he gnashes his teeth and melts away; the desire of the wicked will perish!” Those who reject God’s ways cannot stand the light of the righteous. But the one who fears the LORD will not be shaken.

In the end, the one who perfectly fits this psalm is Christ, who feared the LORD, delighted in his commands, gave freely to the poor, and has been exalted in honor. We are being made like him.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Corinthians 9:6-15 quotes verse 9 in the context of giving. Psalm 111 is the companion. Psalm 1 also describes the blessed man. Proverbs 19:17 says whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD. Matthew 5:14-16 calls us the light of the world. Luke 6:35-36 says be merciful as your Father is merciful. Ephesians 5:1 says be imitators of God. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 commands the rich to be generous. Isaiah 26:3 speaks of perfect peace for those whose mind is stayed on the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where bad news makes you afraid. Pray verse 7 and give that worry to God.

Give something to someone in need this week, quietly. Do it with the attitude of verse 9.

Notice where your character looks like the character of God. Thank him. Notice where it doesn't. Ask him to change it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you gracious, merciful, and righteous.

Tell him you want to fear him and delight in his commandments.

Ask him to give you generosity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 772 · WEEK 111

Psalm 133

How good and pleasant when brothers dwell in unity

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 3 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 133. It is three verses long. It is a Song of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem. Read it slowly twice and picture the two images: oil and dew.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 133 is a psalm of David and belongs to the pilgrim songs. When Israelite families came together from all over the land for the festivals in Jerusalem, they experienced the unity of the people of God. In the context of 1 Corinthians, a church torn by factions, this psalm is a picture of what Paul longed to see. Unity is not an optional extra but a gift and a command.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” (v. 1).
2. “When brothers dwell in unity” (v. 1).
3. “It is like the precious oil on the head” (v. 2).
4. “Running down on the beard, on the beard of Aaron” (v. 2).
5. “Running down on the collar of his robes!” (v. 2).
6. “It is like the dew of Hermon” (v. 3).
7. “Which falls on the mountains of Zion” (v. 3).
8. “For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore” (v. 3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an exclamation: “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” The words “good” and “pleasant” mean something that is both right and delightful. We often think of unity as duty. The psalm says it is a delight. The word translated “brothers” includes the whole family of God. The unity described is among those who “dwell together,” sharing life.

Then two pictures. First, precious oil poured on the head of Aaron the high priest at his consecration (Exodus 29:7, Leviticus 8:12). It ran down on the beard and the collar of his robes. Oil was abundant, fragrant, and set apart for holy use. Unity is like holy oil that flows down from the head over the whole body. It is a lavish, overflowing gift. For Christians, the Head is Christ, and the Spirit he sends is poured out on the whole body. The oil of anointing reaches to the collar and beyond: to every member.

The second picture is dew from Mount Hermon, the tallest mountain in the region, covered in snow and heavy with moisture. In the dry summers, dew was life for the crops. The dew of Hermon falls on the mountains of Zion, which are much farther south and drier. The picture is of refreshment coming down from above to fertilize a dry land. Unity is life-giving.

“For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore.” Notice that the blessing is “commanded.” God designates unity as the place where he gives life. In Christ’s prayer in John 17, he asked that his followers be one, so that the world may believe. And Paul calls the Corinthians to the same unity: “that all of you agree, and that there be no divisions among you.”

We should not romanticize unity. It requires forgiveness, patience, and humility. It does not mean agreeing on everything, but sharing the same Lord, the same gospel, and the same Spirit. Ephesians 4:3 says to be “eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.” The unity is already ours in Christ; our job is to guard and display it.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 29:7 and Leviticus 8:12 describe the anointing of Aaron. Deuteronomy 33:28 mentions dew. John 17:20-23 is Jesus’ prayer for unity. Ephesians 4:1-6 urges us to maintain unity. Colossians 3:12-15 describes the bond of perfect harmony. Philippians 2:1-4 calls for being of one mind. Acts 2:42-47 and 4:32 describe the early church’s unity. 1 Corinthians 1:10 and 12:12-26 treat unity in Corinth. Romans 15:5-6 prays for harmony. Hebrews 13:1 says let brotherly love continue.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a fellow believer you are at odds with. Take a step to be reconciled.

Pray for the unity of your church by name: elders, volunteers, and members.

Thank God for a time when you tasted unity with others, and ask for more.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the unity of his people.

Ask him to pour out his Spirit like precious oil on your church.

Pray for peace in a specific relationship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 773 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:1-58

The resurrection, the gospel's foundation

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:1-58. This is the great resurrection chapter. Read in four parts: the gospel and the witnesses (1-11), the necessity of the resurrection (12-34), the nature of the resurrection body (35-49), and the victory (50-58). The next two days are doctrinal pauses on this chapter, so today read for the shape of the argument.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Some in Corinth were saying "there is no resurrection of the dead." They may have accepted that the soul lives on but not that the body will be raised, a common Greek view. Paul responds with the greatest defense of the resurrection in the Bible. If there is no resurrection, there is no gospel. This chapter is the climax of the letter, and the teaching affects how Christians face death, suffering, and daily work.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "That Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures" (15:3).
2. "But by the grace of God I am what I am, and his grace toward me was not in vain" (15:10).
3. "And if Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is in vain and your faith is in vain" (15:14).
4. "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (15:20).
5. "For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive" (15:22).
6. "The last enemy to be destroyed is death" (15:26).

7. “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” (15:55).
8. “Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is not in vain” (15:58).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the gospel: “I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved.” Then he gives what is likely one of the earliest creeds of the church: “For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures, and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. Then he appeared to more than five hundred brothers at one time, most of whom are still alive, though some have fallen asleep. Then he appeared to James, then to all the apostles. Last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me.” The resurrection is rooted in history and eyewitness testimony. Paul invites the Corinthians to check with the living witnesses. Notice “in accordance with the Scriptures” twice. The gospel is the fulfillment of the Old Testament.

Then the logic of chapters 12 to 34. If there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ has not been raised; if Christ has not been raised, our preaching is in vain, your faith is in vain, we are misrepresenting God, you are still in your sins, and those who have died in Christ have perished. “If in Christ we have hope in this life only, we are of all people most to be pitied.” But the truth is “Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.” The firstfruits is the first part of the harvest, guaranteeing the rest. His resurrection is the start of the general resurrection. The contrast with Adam: “as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive.” Then the order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to him, then the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule, authority, and power. “The last enemy to be destroyed is death.”

Paul answers the question about the kind of body: “How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?” He uses a seed: what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare kernel. God gives it a body as he has chosen. There are different kinds of bodies, glories of sun, moon, and stars. “So it is with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.” Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust (Adam), we shall bear the image of the man of heaven (Christ).

The climax: “Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.” The dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. “Death is swallowed up in victory. O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law, “but thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

And the practical conclusion: “Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is not in vain.” Because of the resurrection, everything we do for the Lord matters forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 24:13-49 and John 20 to 21 describe the resurrection appearances. Acts 2:24-36 and 17:30-32 preach the resurrection. Genesis 3 and Romans 5:12-21 contrast Adam and Christ. Psalm 110:1 and 8:6 are quoted in verses 25 to 27. Isaiah 25:8 and Hosea 13:14 are quoted in verses 54 to 55. Philippians 3:20-21 describes the transformation of our bodies. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 describes the coming of the Lord and the resurrection. Daniel 12:2 predicts the resurrection. Revelation 20:11-21:5 describes the final victory.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 as a summary of the gospel.

Think of someone grieving a loved one who died in Christ. Share with them verse 58 or verse 20.

Ask what “work of the Lord” you could do this week knowing it is not in vain.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gospel of first importance: Christ died, was buried, and was raised.
- Tell him what the resurrection means to you.
- Ask him to make you steadfast and abounding in his work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

“For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.”

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 774 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:1-28; Matthew 28:1-10

The Resurrection of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:1-28 and Matthew 28:1-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the resurrection of Christ. Notice the evidence, the meaning, and the consequences of the empty tomb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The resurrection of Jesus is the central claim of Christianity. Without it, as Paul says, the faith collapses. The four Gospels each tell of the empty tomb, and Paul lists the appearances. Matthew's account is brief and vivid: an earthquake, an angel, and two women who meet the risen Lord. Today we think about what the resurrection of Christ is, why it matters, and how we know.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He is not here, for he has risen, as he said" (Matthew 28:6).
2. "And they came up and took hold of his feet and worshiped him" (Matthew 28:9).
3. "That he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures" (1 Corinthians 15:4).
4. "Then he appeared to more than five hundred brothers at one time, most of whom are still alive" (1 Corinthians 15:6).
5. "And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile and you are still in your sins" (1 Corinthians 15:17).

6. “But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep” (1 Corinthians 15:20).
7. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet” (1 Corinthians 15:25).
8. “That God may be all in all” (1 Corinthians 15:28).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The resurrection of Jesus is the historical event in which God raised the crucified Jesus from the dead on the third day, in a real, physical, glorified body, never to die again. It was not a resuscitation, like Lazarus, who died again. Jesus was raised to a new kind of life: the tomb was empty, and yet his body had new powers. He could pass through closed doors, but he ate fish and invited Thomas to touch his wounds.

The evidence is strong. The tomb was empty, and Jesus’ enemies never produced a body. The women, whose testimony was not prized in that culture, were the first witnesses. He appeared to individuals, to groups, to the Twelve, and to more than five hundred at once. The disciples were transformed from frightened deserters to bold witnesses, willing to die for what they had seen. Even Paul, the persecutor, and James, the skeptical brother of Jesus, were changed. The earliest church worshiped on Sunday, the day of the resurrection.

The meaning is vast. First, the resurrection vindicates Jesus: he is the Son of God (Romans 1:4). Second, it confirms that his death was accepted as payment for sin: “raised for our justification” (Romans 4:25). Third, it defeats death: he is the firstfruits, guaranteeing our resurrection. Fourth, it inaugurates the new creation: the age to come has begun, even though it is not yet complete. Fifth, it establishes his reign: he is seated at the right hand of the Father, and he must reign until all enemies are subdued.

Christians affirm the bodily resurrection, and it is non-negotiable. Some modern theologians have spoken of a “spiritual” resurrection or a change in the disciples’ faith, but the New Testament insists on an empty tomb and a real, physical body. Paul says without the resurrection our faith is futile. But “in fact Christ has been raised.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Matthew 28, two women come to the tomb at dawn. There is a great earthquake as an angel rolls back the stone and sits on it. His appearance is like lightning. The guards shake and become like dead men. The angel says, “Do not be afraid, for I know that you seek Jesus who was crucified. He is not here, for he has risen, as he said. Come, see the place where he lay.” Then, “go quickly and tell his disciples that he has risen from the dead.” The women leave with fear and great joy. Jesus meets them: “Greetings!” They take hold of his feet and

worship him. They touch him, which shows he is not a ghost. And he says: “Do not be afraid; go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee, and there they will see me.” Notice that he calls his frightened disciples “my brothers,” even after they deserted him.

Paul in 1 Corinthians 15 argues from the evidence and then from the implications. Verses 12 to 19 form a chain: if the dead are not raised, Christ is not raised; if Christ is not raised, preaching is empty and faith is futile; we are still in our sins; those who died in Christ are lost; we are the most pitiable of people. But the next verse breaks the chain: “But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.”

In verses 20 to 28, Paul shows the cosmic scope. Death came through a man, and the resurrection of the dead also comes through a man. In Adam all die; in Christ all will be made alive. Each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then those who belong to Christ at his coming. Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death.” Christ’s present reign is the fulfillment of Psalm 110. He reigns now, and the victory over death is certain. At the end, the Son is subjected to the Father, in a loving order within the Trinity, so that God may be all in all.

The resurrection is not simply a doctrine to affirm but a reality to live in. Because Christ is risen, we have forgiveness, hope, and purpose. We can face death without despair.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 16:8-11 predicts the Holy One not seeing corruption (see Acts 2:25-32). Isaiah 53:10-12 foresees the servant’s vindication. Hosea 6:2 mentions the third day. Matthew 12:38-40 is the sign of Jonah. Luke 24 and John 20 to 21 record other appearances. Acts 1:3, 2:32, and 10:40-41 speak of witnesses. Romans 1:4, 4:25, and 6:4-5 give the meaning. Philippians 3:10 speaks of knowing the power of his resurrection. 1 Peter 1:3-5 speaks of a living hope. Revelation 1:17-18 shows the risen Christ holding the keys of death.

STEP 6

Application

Read the account of the resurrection in one Gospel (Matthew 28, Mark 16, Luke 24, or John 20) and notice the details.

Share the hope of the resurrection with someone who is grieving or afraid of death.

On Sunday, remember that you gather on the day of the resurrection.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise Jesus that he has risen as he said.

Thank him for the hope the resurrection gives.

Tell him what you want to say to someone about it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 775 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:35-58; Daniel 12:1-3; John 5:28-29

The Resurrection of the Dead

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:35-58, Daniel 12:1-3, and John 5:28-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on the resurrection of the dead. Notice the nature of the resurrection body and the two destinies.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we studied the resurrection of Christ. Today we look at his promise that his people will be raised. The Christian hope is not an immortal soul floating in a spiritual realm, though believers who die are with Christ (see Day 779). The final hope is bodily resurrection and a new creation. The Old Testament hints at it, and Jesus taught it. Paul's answer to the question "With what kind of body do they come?" is one of the most important passages for the Christian view of the future.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt" (Daniel 12:2).
2. "And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above" (Daniel 12:3).
3. "An hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out" (John 5:28-29).
4. "What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable" (1 Corinthians 15:42).
5. "It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body" (1 Corinthians 15:44).

6. “Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven” (1 Corinthians 15:49).
7. “We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet” (1 Corinthians 15:51-52).
8. “Death is swallowed up in victory” (1 Corinthians 15:54).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Bible teaches that all the dead will be raised bodily, the righteous to eternal life and the unrighteous to judgment. This is the general resurrection. Daniel 12:2 is the clearest Old Testament statement: “Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.” Jesus affirms it in John 5:28-29: all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, “those who have done good to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.” Paul told Felix he had a hope in “a resurrection of both the just and the unjust” (Acts 24:15).

For believers, the resurrection body will be like Christ’s. Paul uses the seed analogy: there is continuity, because the same person is raised, and transformation, because the new body is much greater. It will be imperishable, glorious, powerful, and “spiritual” (that is, animated by the Spirit, not immaterial). Philippians 3:21 says Christ “will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body.” We will recognize one another and be recognizable. The final state is not a disembodied existence, but a new heaven and new earth, where the redeemed live in resurrected bodies in the presence of God.

Christians have different views about the timing and sequence of the end, including whether there is a literal thousand-year reign of Christ (the millennium), whether the resurrection of the righteous and the unrighteous happen at the same time, and how Israel fits in. Premillennialists, amillennialists, and postmillennialists all affirm Christ’s personal, visible return, the bodily resurrection, the final judgment, and the new creation. The difference lies in how to read Revelation 20 and related passages. We should hold our views on timing with humility.

The practical effect of the doctrine is profound. We do not fear the grave. We treat our bodies with dignity. We care for the physical world and for the suffering. We grieve with hope. And we work with confidence, because the final word belongs to God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul anticipates two questions: “How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?” He answers with an analogy: “What you sow does not come to life unless it dies. And what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare kernel.” The seed dies and rises as a plant. God gives it a body as he has chosen. There is continuity and difference. The glories of earthly and heavenly bodies differ, as the sun, moon, and stars differ in glory.

Then the four contrasts: “What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.” Burial is sowing. The body goes into the ground like a seed. The resurrection body is not less physical than the present body, but more: it is fitted for life in the new creation, under the Spirit’s power.

Paul continues, “Thus it is written, The first man Adam became a living being; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit.” Christ is the model and source of our resurrection. “Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven.” Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God, nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable. A change is needed.

Then the mystery: not all will die, but all will be changed “in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.” The perishable body must put on the imperishable, and the mortal body immortality. When this happens, the Scripture will be fulfilled: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” Paul quotes Isaiah 25:8 and Hosea 13:14 and taunts death: “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. But Christ has dealt with sin, and so the sting is removed.

Daniel 12:3 adds a note of glory: “Those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above, and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever.” The people of God will shine. Whatever we do now in faithfulness will not be forgotten.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 25:6-9 and 26:19 anticipate the resurrection. Job 19:25-27 declares “I know that my Redeemer lives.” Ezekiel 37:1-14 is the vision of dry bones. Luke 20:27-40 records Jesus on the resurrection. John 11:21-27 records Jesus saying “I am the resurrection and the life.” Romans 8:11, 8:18-25 and 2 Corinthians 4:14 speak of future resurrection. Philippians 3:20-21 describes the transformation. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts the grieving. Revelation 20 to 22 describes the final judgment and new creation.

STEP 6

Application

Treat your body today as something God will raise: care for it, honor it, use it for his service.

If you have lost someone in Christ, read verses 42 to 44 and imagine them in glory.

Thank God that death is swallowed up in victory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he will raise the dead.

Tell him what you want to say about death in light of this.

Ask him to keep you steadfast in the meantime.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 776 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 16:1-24

The collection; final greetings

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 16:1-24. Paul closes with practical matters: the collection, travel plans, coworkers, and greetings. Notice the way he combines practical details with spiritual urgency.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the soaring heights of chapter 15, Paul returns to earth. Chapter 16 reminds us that ordinary church life, such as money, schedules, hospitality, and greetings, is part of the work of the gospel. The collection is for the poor believers in Jerusalem, a project that Paul was organizing among the Gentile churches. It was a sign of the unity between Jew and Gentile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “On the first day of every week, each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper” (16:2).
2. “For a wide door for effective work has opened to me, and there are many adversaries” (16:9).
3. “Be watchful, stand firm in the faith, act like men, be strong” (16:13).
4. “Let all that you do be done in love” (16:14).
5. “They have devoted themselves to the service of the saints” (16:15).
6. “Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord” (16:19).
7. “Our Lord, come!” (16:22).
8. “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you” (16:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the collection for the saints in Jerusalem. He gave the same instructions to the churches of Galatia. “On the first day of every week, each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper, so that there will be no collecting when I come.” The pattern: regular, personal, proportionate, and planned. The first day of the week is the day of resurrection and of gathering. Giving belongs with worship. Paul plans to send the gift with approved messengers, ensuring accountability.

His travel plans are flexible and subject to God’s will. He will stay in Ephesus until Pentecost, “for a wide door for effective work has opened to me, and there are many adversaries.” Opportunity and opposition often come together. He asks the Corinthians to receive Timothy without fear, and to send him on in peace. Apollos, who he strongly urged to visit, will come when he has opportunity. Notice that Paul does not control his coworkers; he treats them as partners.

Then a series of short commands, like a sergeant’s orders: “Be watchful, stand firm in the faith, act like men, be strong. Let all that you do be done in love.” This last sentence sums up the whole letter. In a church full of pride, division, and misuse of gifts, love is the controlling principle. Paul commends the household of Stephanas, the first converts in Achaia, who have devoted themselves to the service of the saints. Submit to such people, he says, and to every fellow worker. He is glad of the arrival of Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus, for they refreshed his spirit.

The greetings are warm. The churches of Asia send greetings. “Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord.” The early church met in homes. “Greet one another with a holy kiss.” Paul takes the pen in his own hand to sign: “If anyone has no love for the Lord, let him be accursed. Our Lord, come!” The Aramaic word is “Maranatha,” a prayer of the early church for the return of Christ. It reveals the hope behind chapter 15. The letter ends with grace and love: “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you. My love be with you all in Christ Jesus. Amen.” Despite all the rebukes, Paul ends with love for the church.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 11:27-30, Romans 15:25-29, and 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 speak of the collection. Acts 20:7 shows the church gathering on the first day. Acts 18:1-3, 24-28, and 19:1-10 mention Aquila, Priscilla, Apollos, and Ephesus. 1 Thessalonians 5:12-13 asks to respect those who labor.

Hebrews 13:17 asks to submit to leaders. 1 Peter 5:14 mentions the kiss of love. Revelation 22:20 is “Come, Lord Jesus.” 2 Corinthians 9:6-8 teaches cheerful giving. Philippians 4:15-19 shows the Philippians’ gift.

STEP 6

Application

Decide on a regular, planned amount to give to your church or to the poor, and give it joyfully.

Thank someone in your church who serves quietly, like the household of Stephanas.

Pray “Our Lord, come!” at the end of the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the saints who give and serve.

Ask him to help you do all in love.

Pray for someone in your church by name.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

“For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.”

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 777 · WEEK 111

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

REST

Meditation

This is a summary of the gospel, and it was handed down from the earliest days.

"As of first importance." Paul places this message at the top of the list. Many things in the Christian life matter, but some matter most. The death and resurrection of Christ are the foundation.

"What I also received." Paul did not invent the gospel. He received it, probably from the first apostles within a few years of the event, and he delivered it. We too receive and pass on.

"That Christ died for our sins." Notice the three parts: the person (Christ), the event (died), and the purpose (for our sins). His death was not an accident but a substitution, dealing with our guilt.

“In accordance with the Scriptures.” The cross is the fulfillment of what the Old Testament promised, in Isaiah 53, Psalm 22, and the sacrifices.

“That he was buried.” The burial proves he truly died.

“That he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.” The tomb was empty because Christ was alive. This too was foretold.

When the world offers other messages, say this verse. These two verses are the heart of what we believe.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of 1 Corinthians. Chapters 12 to 14 gave Paul’s teaching on spiritual gifts, the body of Christ, and the more excellent way of love, and a doctrinal pause considered the gifts and the unity of the body. Psalms 111 and 112 sang about remembering the works of the LORD and becoming like him, and Psalm 133 pictured the beauty of unity. Chapter 15 gave the resurrection: the gospel of first importance, Christ the firstfruits, the nature of the resurrection body, and the victory over death. Two doctrinal pauses studied the resurrection of Christ and the resurrection of the dead. Chapter 16 closed the letter with the collection, greetings, and the cry “Our Lord, come!”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul calls the death and resurrection of Christ “of first importance.” What other things in your spiritual life have crowded into that first place? How can you put the gospel back at the center?

The resurrection of Jesus is the firstfruits of the resurrection of believers. How does knowing your body will be raised change how you see aging, illness, or death?

Paul ends his long letter with “Let all that you do be done in love.” Where in your life this week will it be hardest to do everything in love? What will you ask Christ for help with?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he died for your sins and was raised on the third day.

Tell him what you want to hold on to this week.

Rest in him.

DAY 778 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18

Comfort in suffering; the new covenant ministry

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18. Paul writes his most personal letter. Notice the comfort in suffering in chapter 1, the aroma of Christ in chapter 2, and the new covenant ministry in chapter 3.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After writing 1 Corinthians, Paul's relationship with the church became strained. He made a painful visit, wrote a severe letter (now lost), and waited anxiously for news from Titus. When Titus brought good news in Macedonia, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians, a letter full of emotion. It defends his ministry against critics who called him weak and unimpressive, and it reveals the heart of a pastor who suffers for his people. Chapters 1 to 3 introduce the main themes: comfort through affliction and the glory of the new covenant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Father of mercies and God of all comfort" (1:3).
2. "Indeed, we felt that we had received the sentence of death. But that was to make us rely not on ourselves but on God who raises the dead" (1:9).
3. "For all the promises of God find their Yes in him" (1:20).
4. "Who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee" (1:22).
5. "You show that you are a letter from Christ delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts" (3:3).

6. “Who has made us competent to be ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit. For the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life” (3:6).
7. “Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom” (3:17).
8. “Beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with a blessing: “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our affliction, so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.” Comfort is not a private possession. We receive in order to give. Suffering abounds for Christ, but through Christ comfort abounds too. He describes a recent affliction in Asia that was so severe that they despaired of life. “Indeed, we felt that we had received the sentence of death. But that was to make us rely not on ourselves but on God who raises the dead.” Suffering teaches dependence.

He explains why he did not come to Corinth as planned: he was sparing them. His “Yes” is not “Yes and No.” Then a beautiful statement on the faithfulness of God: “For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory.” Christ is the fulfillment of every promise. It is God who establishes us with you in Christ, anointed us, “put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.” The Spirit is the down payment on our inheritance.

Chapter 2 refers to the painful letter written “out of much affliction and anguish of heart and with many tears.” When someone had caused grief, the church disciplined him. Now Paul says it is time to forgive and comfort him, “so that he may not be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.” Forgiveness protects against Satan’s schemes. Then a picture of triumph: “But thanks be to God, who in Christ always leads us in triumphal procession, and through him spreads the fragrance of the knowledge of him everywhere.” The image is of a Roman victory parade, with incense burning. For some it is the aroma of life; for others, death. “Who is sufficient for these things?” Not Paul, but God.

In chapter 3, Paul defends his credentials. “You yourselves are our letter of recommendation, written on our hearts… a letter from Christ delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.” This echoes Ezekiel 36 and Jeremiah 31. Our competence is from God, “who has made us competent to be ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit. For the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.” The old covenant, engraved in letters on stone, came with glory, but it was a ministry of death and condemnation, fading. The new covenant ministry of the Spirit and of

righteousness has far greater glory, and it remains. This is a key text for progressive covenantalism: the old covenant was glorious, but it was temporary, and the new covenant exceeds it in glory. Moses put a veil over his face so the Israelites would not gaze at the fading glory. A veil lies over hearts when the old covenant is read, "because only through Christ is it taken away."

The chapter ends with freedom and transformation. "Where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom. And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit." We become what we behold. By looking at Christ in Scripture, we are changed.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:29-35 tells of Moses' veil. Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Ezekiel 36:26-27 promise the new covenant. Romans 8:1-4 and 15:4 are related. Ephesians 1:13-14 speaks of the seal and guarantee. Isaiah 51:12 speaks of comfort. Philippians 3:3-11 compares old and new. Hebrews 8 to 10 explain the superiority of the new covenant. Colossians 1:15 calls Christ the image of God. Romans 12:2 speaks of transformation.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a suffering you have been through. Whom can you now comfort with the comfort you received?

Spend ten minutes looking at Christ in a Gospel passage and ask the Spirit to transform you.

Thank God that all his promises are Yes in Christ. Say "Amen" to a specific promise.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Father of mercies for comforting you.
- Ask him to help you comfort someone else with the comfort you received.
- Thank him for the ministry of the new covenant.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 779 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 5:1-10; Philippians 1:21-24; Luke 23:39-43

Death and the Intermediate State

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 5:1-10, Philippians 1:21-24, and Luke 23:39-43. Today is a doctrinal pause on death and the intermediate state, the time between a believer's death and the resurrection. Notice what Paul expects and what Jesus promises.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday and the day before, we studied the resurrection of the dead at the end of the age. But what happens to believers who die before Christ returns? Paul was facing possible death in Asia, and in Philippians he wrote from prison, aware that he might be executed. Their words, along with Jesus' promise to the thief on the cross, tell us what the New Testament says about the time between death and resurrection.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For we know that if the tent that is our earthly home is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens" (2 Corinthians 5:1).
2. "For we walk by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7).
3. "We would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord" (2 Corinthians 5:8).
4. "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ" (2 Corinthians 5:10).
5. "For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain" (Philippians 1:21).
6. "My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better" (Philippians 1:23).

7. “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom” (Luke 23:42).

8. “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in Paradise” (Luke 23:43).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The intermediate state is the condition of a person between death and the resurrection of the body. Scripture teaches that when a believer dies, the person is immediately with Christ, in conscious fellowship and joy, although without a resurrection body. Paul says to be “away from the body” is to be “at home with the Lord.” He says that departing is “far better” than staying. Jesus told the penitent thief, “Today you will be with me in Paradise.” This is the common evangelical understanding, and it is a great comfort.

This state is not the final one. Paul pictures it as being “unclothed” (2 Corinthians 5:3-4), awaiting the “clothing” of the resurrection body. The final hope remains the resurrection and the new creation. The intermediate state is a waiting period, but it is a good one, in the presence of Christ.

Several other views exist. Some Christians hold to “soul sleep,” the idea that the dead are unconscious until the resurrection. The language of “sleep” in the New Testament describes how death looks from our side, but passages like Philippians 1 and Luke 23 point to conscious fellowship. The Roman Catholic Church teaches purgatory, a place of purification after death for those who die in grace but not fully cleansed. Protestants reject this because Christ’s work on the cross is sufficient, and Scripture speaks of immediate presence with Christ. Other traditions emphasize that God’s people await the resurrection, stressing the whole person.

For unbelievers, the New Testament speaks of a state of waiting for judgment, with the final judgment to come (Luke 16:19-31; Hebrews 9:27). All will appear before the judgment seat of Christ. For believers, this is not a judgment about our standing, which is secure in Christ, but about our works, for reward. The thought of that day motivates faithful service.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins 2 Corinthians 5 with a contrast between the earthly tent and the eternal building. A tent is temporary; our bodies are like tents, vulnerable and short-lived. If the tent is destroyed, we have a building from God, “a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.” In the meantime, “we groan, longing to put on our heavenly dwelling.” He does not want to be unclothed but further clothed, “so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life.” God has prepared us for this and given us the Spirit as a guarantee.

“So we are always of good courage. We know that while we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord, for we walk by faith, not by sight. Yes, we are of good courage, and we would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord.” To be “at home with the Lord” is the heart of the intermediate state. Whether at home or away, our aim is to please him, “for we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive what is due for what he has done in the body, whether good or evil.” For the believer, this is a day for evaluation and reward, not condemnation (Romans 8:1).

In Philippians 1, Paul is in prison, uncertain whether he will live or die. He writes, “For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain.” He is hard-pressed between the two: “My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better. But to remain in the flesh is more necessary on your account.” Notice his confidence: death does not end fellowship with Christ; it increases it. The word “depart” was used of a ship loosing its moorings or a tent being taken down.

In Luke 23, one of the criminals crucified with Jesus rebukes the other, acknowledges his own guilt, and says, “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.” He had no time for baptism, good works, or a long spiritual track record. Jesus answers with a promise: “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in Paradise.” Salvation by grace through faith, and immediate presence with Christ, in one scene. “Today.” The thief received what Paul described.

Death is still an enemy, and Christians grieve. But it has lost its sting, and it is the doorway to being with Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23:4 speaks of walking through the valley of the shadow of death. Psalm 116:15 says the death of his saints is precious. Ecclesiastes 12:7 speaks of the spirit returning to God. Luke 16:19-31 tells of the rich man and Lazarus. John 14:1-3 promises a place with him. Acts 7:59 records Stephen’s prayer, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit.” Hebrews 12:22-24 mentions the spirits of the righteous made perfect. Revelation 6:9-11 shows souls under the altar. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts the grieving. Romans 14:7-9 says whether we live or die, we are the Lord’s.

STEP 6

Application

Write down what you believe about what happens when a Christian dies. Compare it to these passages.

Pray for someone who is facing death or grief. Share Philippians 1:21 with them.

Ask what it would mean to say, “To me to live is Christ,” in your daily work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you think about death today.
- Thank Jesus that to live is Christ and to die is gain.
- Thank him that to be away from the body is to be at home with him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 780 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21

Treasure in jars of clay; ambassadors for Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21. This is among Paul's most moving writing. Notice the treasure in jars of clay, the contrast between the outer and inner self, the new creation, and the ministry of reconciliation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has been defending his ministry against critics who find him weak. In these chapters he explains that weakness is how the power of God is shown. He is not discouraged by suffering because he sees the unseen and eternal. And he describes his message as the word of reconciliation, the center of the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For what we proclaim is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus" sake' (4:5).
2. "For God, who said, Let light shine out of darkness, has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (4:6).
3. "But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us" (4:7).
4. "So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day" (4:16).
5. "For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison" (4:17).

6. “Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come” (5:17).
7. “Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, God making his appeal through us” (5:20).
8. “For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that because they have received mercy, they do not lose heart. They have renounced disgraceful, underhanded ways; they do not use cunning or tamper with God’s word. They commend themselves by the open statement of the truth. If the gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing, “in their case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.” Preachers do not proclaim themselves but “Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus” sake.’ And the great reason for hope: “For God, who said, Let light shine out of darkness, has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.” Conversion is a new creation, like the first day of creation.

Then the paradox: “But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.” The treasure is the gospel; the jars of clay are cheap, fragile, ordinary containers. We are weak so that God’s power is clear. He lists the pressures: “afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed.” We always carry in the body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our bodies. “So death is at work in us, but life in you.”

Because of faith in the God who raises the dead, “we do not lose heart.” The outer self wastes away; the inner self is renewed day by day. “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison, as we look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen. For the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.” Paul does not minimize suffering; elsewhere he lists beatings, shipwrecks, and sleeplessness. He weighs it against eternal glory.

Chapter 5 continues with the longing for the resurrection body (see the previous pause) and then turns to Christ’s love. “For the love of Christ controls us, because we have concluded this: that one has died for all, therefore all have died; and he died for all, that those who live might no longer live for themselves but for him who for their sake died and was raised.” This changes how we see everyone: “From now on, therefore, we regard no one according to the flesh.” And then: “Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed

away; behold, the new has come." All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation. "In Christ God was reconciling the world to himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation." So we are ambassadors for Christ. "We implore you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God." The chapter ends with the heart of the gospel: "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." The great exchange: our sin was counted to Christ, and his righteousness is counted to us.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:3 is the creation of light. Isaiah 9:2 and 60:1-3 speak of light shining in darkness. Colossians 1:15-20 describes Christ as the image of God and the reconciler. Romans 5:10-11 speaks of reconciliation. Ephesians 2:11-22 speaks of reconciliation between Jew and Gentile and with God. Isaiah 53:4-6, 10-12 and Galatians 3:13 teach substitution. Isaiah 43:19 speaks of a new thing. Revelation 21:5 says "Behold, I am making all things new." Isaiah 49:8 is quoted in 2 Corinthians 6:2. Matthew 5:11-12 and Romans 8:18 speak of suffering and glory.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you feel like a cracked jar of clay. Offer that weakness to God as a display of his power.

Practice looking at the unseen. Spend time today remembering what is eternal.

Be an ambassador: speak to someone about being reconciled to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for shining in your heart the light of the knowledge of his glory.
- Tell him what makes you feel like a jar of clay.
- Ask him to make you a faithful ambassador.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 781 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15

Holiness; Paul's hardships; generous giving

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15. These four chapters hold several themes: the day of salvation, holiness and separation, godly grief and repentance, and generous giving. Read the appeal for the collection in chapters 8 and 9 slowly, noticing its motive.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his defense of the ministry and moves to appeals. He urges the Corinthians not to receive God's grace in vain, to pursue holiness, and to complete their promised gift for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus has brought news that the church repented after Paul's painful letter, and Paul rejoices. The collection in chapters 8 and 9 is the longest discussion of Christian giving in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, now is the favorable time; behold, now is the day of salvation" (6:2).
2. "As sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing everything" (6:10).
3. "For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death" (7:10).
4. "For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich" (8:9).
5. "For if the readiness is there, it is acceptable according to what a person has, not according to what he does not have" (8:12).

6. “Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully” (9:6).

7. “Each one must give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver” (9:7).

8. “Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!” (9:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul urges the Corinthians, as God’s fellow workers, not to receive the grace of God in vain. Quoting Isaiah 49:8, he says, “Behold, now is the favorable time; behold, now is the day of salvation.” He then describes his own ministry through a list of hardships and virtues: afflictions, hardships, calamities, beatings, imprisonments, riots, labors, sleepless nights, hunger; by purity, knowledge, patience, kindness, the Holy Spirit, genuine love, truthful speech, and the power of God. “As sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing everything.” The Christian life is full of paradox.

Then comes a call to holiness: “Do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers. For what partnership has righteousness with lawlessness? Or what fellowship has light with darkness?” This is not a call to withdraw from the world but to avoid being joined to what contradicts our devotion to Christ. The reason: “For we are the temple of the living God.” God promises, “I will make my dwelling among them and walk among them… I will be a father to you, and you shall be sons and daughters to me.” The chapter ends with the call to cleanse ourselves from every defilement of body and spirit, bringing holiness to completion in the fear of God.

In chapter 7, Paul rejoices that the church responded to his painful letter. “For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.” Worldly grief is sorrow at being caught; godly grief is sorrow at sinning against God. Titus was refreshed by their response, and Paul’s joy is complete.

Chapters 8 and 9 speak of the collection. The Macedonian churches, in a severe test of affliction, with abundance of joy and extreme poverty, overflowed in a wealth of generosity. They gave beyond their means, begging earnestly for the favor of taking part. Notice the order: “They gave themselves first to the Lord and then by the will of God to us.” Giving flows from devotion. Then the ground of all giving: “For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich.” The incarnation is the model of generosity. Paul does not command but tests the sincerity of their love. Principles: give willingly, according to what you have, so that there may be fairness. Transparency and accountability are important: Titus and others will handle the funds so that no one can criticize.

Chapter 9 gives encouragement. “Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully.” “Each one must give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.” This does not promise material wealth in return; the harvest is righteousness and thanksgiving. “God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that having all sufficiency in all things at all times, you may abound in every good work.” Quoting Psalm 112:9, “He has distributed freely, he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures forever.” The result of generosity is thanksgiving to God. The chapter ends with praise: “Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!” The ultimate gift is Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 49:8 is quoted in 6:2. Leviticus 26:11-12 and Ezekiel 37:27 stand behind 6:16. Psalm 112:9 is quoted in 9:9. Acts 11:27-30 and Romans 15:25-27 describe the collection. Philippians 2:5-8 shows Christ’s self-emptying. Philippians 4:10-20 speaks of the Philippians’ gift. Luke 21:1-4 records the widow’s offering. Proverbs 11:24-25 and 22:9 speak of generosity. Matthew 6:19-21 says where your treasure is, there your heart will be. Psalm 51:17 and Luke 18:13 show true repentance.

STEP 6

Application

Choose an amount to give that stretches you. Do it cheerfully, not by compulsion.

Distinguish worldly grief from godly grief in your own heart. Are you sorry for the sin, or for the consequences?

Meditate on 8:9 and remember the cost of Christ’s generosity to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for becoming poor so that you might become rich.
- Ask him to make you cheerful in giving.
- Tell him how you want to give this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 782 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14

Paul's authority; boasting in weakness

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14. Paul's tone shifts here, as he defends his apostleship against false teachers. Read with an ear for his irony and his pain. Pay special attention to the thorn in the flesh and the answer he received in 12:7-10.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Some in Corinth, influenced by self-styled "super-apostles," dismissed Paul as unimpressive in person and contemptible in speech. They boasted of credentials, visions, and eloquence. Paul is reluctant to boast, but to defend the gospel he does a kind of "fool's boasting" in which he boasts of his weaknesses. This section reverses worldly values and gives one of the Bible's most important teachings on God's strength in weakness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds" (10:4).
2. "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord" (10:17).
3. "But I am afraid that as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a sincere and pure devotion to Christ" (11:3).
4. "If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness" (11:30).
5. "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (12:9).
6. "For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (12:10).
7. "Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves" (13:5).

8 “The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all” (13:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins by appealing “by the meekness and gentleness of Christ.” He is accused of being bold when away and timid when present. He warns that when he comes, he may have to be bold. “For though we walk in the flesh, we are not waging war according to the flesh. For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ.” The spiritual battle is fought with truth, prayer, and the word, not with manipulation or force. He refuses to compare himself with those who commend themselves. “Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord. For it is not the one who commends himself who is approved, but the one whom the Lord commends.”

In chapter 11, Paul’s jealousy for the church leads him to a painful comparison. He has betrothed them to one husband, to present them as a pure virgin to Christ. “But I am afraid that as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a sincere and pure devotion to Christ.” The false teachers preach another Jesus, a different spirit, a different gospel. Paul calls them “false apostles, deceitful workmen, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ. And no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.” Their credentials are impressive, but Paul tallies his own: far more labors, far more imprisonments, with countless beatings, often near death. Five times he received thirty-nine lashes; three times beaten with rods; once stoned; three times shipwrecked; a night and a day adrift at sea; in danger from rivers, robbers, his own people, Gentiles, the city, the wilderness, false brothers; in toil and hardship, sleepless nights, hunger, cold. “And, apart from other things, there is the daily pressure on me of my anxiety for all the churches.” Then: “If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness,” and he tells of being lowered in a basket through a window in the wall at Damascus.

In chapter 12, he speaks of a vision, “a man in Christ” caught up to the third heaven, hearing things that cannot be told. He refrains from boasting of this. “So to keep me from becoming conceited because of the surpassing greatness of the revelations, a thorn was given me in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to harass me.” We do not know what the thorn was: an illness, a person, a temptation. Three times he pleaded with the Lord to remove it. “But he said to me, My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness. Therefore I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me. For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong.” God’s answer was not removal but sufficiency. This verse has comforted countless suffering believers.

Paul closes with warnings and tenderness. He fears he will find quarreling, jealousy, and unrepentance. “Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves. Or do you not realize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you?” The aim is restoration, not demolition. “Aim for restoration, comfort one another, agree with one another, live in peace; and the God of love and peace will be with you.” The letter ends with the benediction: “The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all.” It is one of the clearest Trinitarian blessings in the New Testament.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 9:23-24 is the source of 10:17. Genesis 3 describes the serpent’s deceit. Galatians 1:6-9 also warns of false gospels. Ephesians 6:10-18 describes spiritual warfare. Acts 9:23-25 and 14:19 tell of the basket and the stoning. Job 1 to 2 shows Satan allowed to afflict. Isaiah 40:28-31 promises strength to the weary. Philippians 4:13 says I can do all things through him who strengthens me. Hebrews 4:15-16 offers grace to help in time of need. Romans 8:35-39 and 1 Peter 5:10 speak of suffering and grace.

STEP 6

Application

Name your “thorn.” Bring it to the Lord as Paul did. Listen for his answer.

Read 12:9 aloud and apply it to a current weakness.

Examine yourself as 13:5 says. Is Christ in you? Do you have the marks of faith?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God your “thorn,” and tell him what it is.
- Thank him that his grace is sufficient and his power is perfected in weakness.
- Ask him to teach you to boast in weakness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 783 · WEEK 112

Review and Reflection

Unit 21 review, Law, Gospel & Church Life, Galatians, Corinthians

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me."
>
> GALATIANS 2:20

REST

Meditation

Paul wrote these words in the middle of an argument about justification, but they are as personal as anything in his letters. They are the unit's key.

"I have been crucified with Christ." Paul speaks of a past event with present effect. When Christ died, those who are in him died with him. The old self, the power of sin, and the curse of the law all came to an end at the cross.

"It is no longer I who live." The self-centered life, the one that lives for its own glory, has been put to death. This is not the loss of personality but of the old master.

"But Christ who lives in me." The risen Christ now lives in the believer by his Spirit. He is not just a teacher to be imitated or a debt-payer to be thanked, but the life within us.

The rest of the verse, which you should read, says: "And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." We live by trusting him, and the basis is his love and his sacrifice.

This verse answers legalism, which says do more. It answers license, which says do what you want. The answer is union: Christ's death is mine and Christ's life is mine.

When you feel the pull of self-reliance or of sin, say this verse. You are not alone, and you are not what you were.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read Galatians, 1 Corinthians, and 2 Corinthians, three letters that show the gospel at work in churches. In Galatians, Paul defended the gospel against those who added the law to faith: there is no other gospel, a person is justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law, Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us, and in Christ we are adopted as sons and heirs. We walk by the Spirit, bear his fruit, and boast only in the cross. In 1 Corinthians, you saw a messy, gifted church corrected by the cross: the word of the cross is the power of God, ministers are servants and stewards, the church is God's temple, and Christians use their freedom in love. You studied the Lord's Supper as the meal that proclaims the Lord's death until he comes, spiritual gifts as given by one Spirit for the common good of one body, and love as the more excellent way. Chapter 15 gave the gospel of first importance and the hope of the resurrection of Christ and of the dead. In 2 Corinthians, you saw comfort in affliction, the new covenant ministry of the Spirit, the treasure in jars of clay, the new creation, the ministry of reconciliation, the grace of giving, and the sufficiency of grace in weakness. Doctrinal pauses covered adoption, the Lord's Supper, spiritual gifts, the resurrection of Christ, the resurrection of the dead, and death and the intermediate state. Psalms 33, 62, 111, 112, and 133 sang of God's word, rest in God alone, remembering his works, generosity, and unity.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the "different gospel" Paul is writing against in Galatians?

Read Galatians 1:6-9 and 2:15-21. What was added to faith in Christ, and why does Paul say that adding anything destroys the gospel? Where might a version of this temptation appear today?

What does "justification by faith" mean practically?

Consider Galatians 2:16, 3:1-14, and 5:1-6. How does it change your view of yourself, your failures, your obedience, and other people when you rest on Christ's finished work instead of your own performance?

Why does Paul say "I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified"?

Look at 1 Corinthians 1:18-2:5. What was wrong with the Corinthians' approach to wisdom and leaders? Why is the cross both foolish to the world and the power of God?

What does the resurrection of 1 Corinthians 15 have to do with everyday Christian living?

Read 1 Corinthians 15:12-20 and 15:50-58. If Christ is raised, what follows for how we face death, suffering, our bodies, and our work for the Lord?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel in Galatians and Corinthians.

Tell him where you have seen law and gospel, grace and church life, together.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 784 · WEEK 112

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Corinthians 12:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness."

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

REST

Meditation

These are the words of the Lord Jesus to Paul, spoken after he pleaded three times for relief from his thorn.

"My grace is sufficient for you." The Lord does not say, "I will remove it," but "My grace is enough." Grace here means God's favor and strength given to us in Christ. There is no situation in which it runs out. Paul needed daily grace, and so do we.

"For my power is made perfect in weakness." Weakness is not an obstacle to God's work but an opportunity for it. When we are strong in ourselves, we credit ourselves; when we are weak, the power of Christ is clearly seen. Paul went on to say, "I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me."

This verse reverses the world's logic. The world says to hide weakness and project strength. The gospel says to bring weakness to Christ. The cross itself is the great display of power in weakness.

When you are tired, limited, struggling with a thorn, or aware of your inadequacy, say this verse. Christ is not disappointed by your weakness; he is glorified in it. His grace is enough for today.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the unit with 2 Corinthians. In chapters 1 to 3, Paul blessed God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, taught that all the promises of God find their Yes in Christ, and described the new covenant ministry of the Spirit that transforms us from one degree of glory to another. A doctrinal pause on death and the intermediate state showed that to be absent from the body is to be at home with the Lord. Chapters 4 and 5 spoke of the treasure in jars of clay, the inner self renewed day by day, the new creation, the ministry of reconciliation, and the great exchange in which Christ was made sin so that we might become the righteousness of God. Chapters 6 to 9 called us to holiness, godly grief, and cheerful generosity, grounded in Christ who became poor for our sake. Chapters 10 to 13 closed with Paul's boasting in weakness, the thorn in the flesh, and the promise that Christ's grace is sufficient. The unit review on Day 783 drew the three letters together around Galatians 2:20.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul's thorn was not removed, but he received grace. What weakness, limitation, or hardship in your life might God be using to display his power? How might you boast in it?

Second Corinthians 5:21 says Christ was made sin for us so that we might become the righteousness of God. What does it mean to you that your sin was counted to him and his righteousness to you?

Paul says we are ambassadors for Christ, entrusted with the message of reconciliation. Who in your life needs to hear it from you? What is one step you can take this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his grace is sufficient.

Thank him that his power is made perfect in weakness.

Rest in him.